

The Longest Flight

David "The k!nG" Orkwar

Copyright Page

THE LONGEST FLIGHT

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Acknowledgments

dUaLiTy

the duality of thought

THE DUALITY OF OPINION

tHe dUality oF eMotion

The Duality Of Souls

The duality in EXISTENCE

duality was, duality is & duality will always be...

The flight of this book was fueled by the one million words written in the dark, and to the anonymous readers who navigated those early journeys with me: thank you for being the wind beneath my wings before I even knew I was flying.

To my family and mentors in Abuja, and to the visions of New York City that keep my horizon bright: your belief in the "multihyphenate" path has been the ultimate sanctuary.

I must offer a profound tribute to the beautiful soul that was **William Shakespeare**. He was a man of incomparable excellence who understood that magic is not a commodity to be traded, but a legacy to be forged. He pursued greatness with a purity of spirit, refusing to lose his soul to the pursuit of money, and in doing so, he immortalized it. He left behind a treasury of magic for us to enjoy, a script written in the stars that reminds us that even a tragedy can be a masterpiece.

To the engineers of the **A350-1000ULR** and the visionaries behind **Project Sunrise**, thank you for creating a "Qantas Bubble" where time and logic could finally stand still.

Finally, to you, the reader: thank you for trusting the "First Man" and taking this seat beside me. While this specific journey has reached the gate, I invite you to remain seated. The destination is merely a transition. As the years roll by, I look forward to welcoming you as we embark on new explorations into the depths of **Fantasy**, the whispers of the **Supernatural**, and the cold, bright horizons of **Futuristic Sci-Fi**.

The ink is never truly dry.

David "The k!nG" Orkwar

About the book

23 hours of pressurized silence. Two sunrises. One fated collision.

She is **Jewel**, a world-famous pop star performing a happiness she doesn't feel, traveling toward a safe, predictable future in London that feels more like a gilded cage than a dream. He is **Terdoo**, a man of impenetrable silence and staggering wealth—a mysterious ghost moving through the high-stakes world of the global elite with a "Cold Void" where his heart used to be.

Trapped together in the silver sanctuary of the world's longest flight from Sydney to London, the rules of the ground no longer apply. High above the Indian Ocean, in a pressurized vacuum of luxury and shadows, a chance encounter turns into an intimate, high-altitude odyssey that neither was prepared for.

In the quiet of the first-class suites, between a mysterious bartender who shouldn't exist, a pilot with a score to settle, and a leather-bound journal filled with fated poetry, the distance between them begins to dissolve. But as the A350-1000ULR roars through the polar night toward a Valentine's Day dawn, they must face a terrifying truth: the higher you fly, the harder it is to ignore the pull of destiny.

Prologue

The automatic glass doors of the First Class curbside entrance slid open with a whisper, admitting the scent of the late afternoon—a mild, twenty-two-degree breeze rolling off Botany Bay that carried the salt of the ocean and the exhaust of a thousand distant engines—and Terdoo Yimam stepped out of the black sedan and into the hushed sanctity of the private check-in lounge. He moved with a slowness that defied the frantic ticking of the airport clocks, a man existing in his own gravity, and he adjusted the collar of his navy Harrington jacket while the personal host collected his passport with the reverence usually reserved for religious texts. *The noise is gone.* It was 5:00 PM, three hours before the metal bird was due to tear itself from the earth, but Terdoo did not believe in rushing, for rushing was an admission that time had power over you, and he preferred to exist in the spaces between the seconds where the air was still and the light was golden.

He walked through the expedited security lane, the vintage loose-fit pants flowing around his legs with a soft rustle, and the soles of his Onitsuka Tiger Mexico 66s made no sound on the polished terrazzo floor, leaving no trace that he had ever been there at all.

Inside the lounge, the world was aggressively filtered, scrubbed of jet fuel and panic until it smelled only of cold marble and the ghost of expensive champagne, and Terdoo spent the next hour in a state of deliberate suspension, letting the heat of a hot stone massage seep into his trapezius muscles until his bones felt heavy and liquid. By 7:00 PM, he was sitting in a high-backed leather chair, a glass of sparkling water untouched on the table, wearing his sunglasses indoors not out of vanity but out of a desire to put a pane of glass between his eyes and the rest of the human race.

Then, the atmosphere fractured.

It wasn't a sound, but a vibration, a sudden intrusion of static into his carefully curated silence, and he watched over the rim of his glass as Jewel and her manager entered the lounge, bringing with them a cloud of kinetic, nervous energy that seemed to rattle the ice in the buckets. *Radiant chaos.* Terdoo did not know who she was, a fact that would have stunned the paparazzi waiting outside the terminal, but he observed the way she sat on the edge of the velvet armchair, her spine rigid as a bowstring, while the piano notes of Yiruma's *River Flows in You* drifted from the ceiling speakers, a gentle, melancholy loop that seemed to mock the tension tightening the skin around her eyes.

The manager leaned over the polished granite counter, his knuckles turning the color of bone against the dark stone.

"I don't care about the cost," the manager hissed, his voice a frantic wire snapping in the quiet room. "We need the privacy. She cannot be in the back."

Jewel looked down at her hands.
They were trembling.
She made a fist.

She felt the familiar constriction in her throat, a physical band of iron tightening around her windpipe, and she tried to focus on the soothing, repetitive piano melody, but the music sounded distorted to her ears, warping into a discordant screech that matched the pressure building behind her ribs. *I am going to shatter right here on the carpet.* She watched the flight board flip its yellow letters, a cascading waterfall of destinations that weren't hers, and she thought of the ring sitting in the velvet box in her carry-on, the heavy promise of a fiancé waiting in London, a safe and predictable future that currently felt a million miles away from this moment of suffocation. The Official behind the desk was shaking her head, a slow, pendulum motion of denial.

"I cannot manufacture a seat," The Official said, her voice smooth and practiced. "The flight is full. The only remaining seats are the two at the rear bulkhead, near the lavatories."

Jewel felt the blood drain from her face, a cold wash of sensation that left her lightheaded, because the thought of the press of bodies, the camera phones, the wet heat of strangers breathing her air, made the skin on her arms prickle with a phantom itch she couldn't scratch.

Terdoo stood up.
He adjusted his cuffs.
He walked into the storm.

He moved like smoke, crossing the lounge with long, lazy strides that ate up the distance, and he didn't look at Jewel, though he could feel the heat of her distress radiating against his side like a radiator in a cold room. He stopped at the counter, the sudden presence of his six-foot-two frame casting a shadow over the paperwork, and he took off his sunglasses, folding them with a slow, deliberate click to reveal eyes that were dark, bottomless, and utterly devoid of the panic that filled the rest of the room.

"Take it," Terdoo said, his voice a low texture like tires on wet pavement.

He placed his boarding pass on the cool stone counter.

"I beg your pardon?" The manager blinked, his mouth hanging slightly open.

"The suite," Terdoo continued, and he didn't look at the ticket or the board, but kept his gaze fixed somewhere just past The Official's shoulder, as if reading a message written in the dust motes. "Exchange it for the two in the back."

Jewel turned her head, the movement sharp and involuntary, and she looked up at him, really looked at him, taking in the sharp angle of his jaw and the low taper of his haircut, and for a terrifying second, her heart hammered a rhythm against her ribs that had nothing to do with the flight and everything to do with the sudden, towering presence of him. *He is handsome*. The thought arrived unbidden, a traitorous whisper that she tried to squash immediately under the weight of her loyalty to the man waiting in London, but her eyes refused to look away.

"You... you're giving up your seat?" The Official asked, her professional mask slipping to reveal the raw confusion underneath.

"I prefer the view from the back," Terdoo lied, the falsehood sliding easily off his tongue.

The Official stamped the papers, the rhythmic *thud-thud* sounding like a heartbeat, and she slid the two economy boarding passes across the granite. Terdoo reached for them at the same moment Jewel reached out to stop him, to thank him, to verify he was real.

Her fingers brushed his.

The air snapped.

A circuit closed.

It wasn't a spark, but a shockwave, a sudden, violent alignment of atoms that made Terdoo pause, his hand hovering over the paper, and for a single, impossible moment, the piano music from the speakers stopped completely—not a pause in the track, but a total silence in the room—before resuming the melody exactly where it had left off. He looked down at her hand, his dark eyes narrowing slightly as if he had found a flaw in a diamond, and she felt the breath catch in her throat, a physical hook that pulled her toward him.

He took the economy tickets.

He did not smile.

He pulled away.

"Boarding is starting, enjoy the view from the window." he said, his voice flat, creating a wall between them that he had no intention of climbing.

He handed the First Class pass to the stunned manager and stepped back, retreating into the lounge, leaning against a pillar with his hands in the pockets of his vintage pants, becoming a statue of observation. The manager grabbed Jewel's elbow, urging her toward the gate, toward the safety and the luxury she needed, but she felt a resistance in her legs, a magnetic drag fighting the forward motion.

She walked toward the glass doors.

She stopped at the threshold.

She looked back.

Across the expanse of the lounge, Terdoo was watching her, his face unreadable, a cold and nonchalant void in the center of the room, but as their eyes locked across the distance, she felt a sudden warmth spread through her chest, hot and intoxicating, like whiskey swallowed too fast on a winter night.

It was going to be a really long flight.

Chapter 1

Sydney Kingsford Smith Airport (SYD)

Date: 12th February, 2027

Time: 8:00 PM (Sydney) / 09:00 AM (London)

The gentle hum of the lounge was broken only by the rhythmic flipping of the vintage Solari departure board on the wall, a mechanical cascade of yellow letters that sounded like the shuffling of a thousand dry leaves, and Terdoo watched the time click over to 7:30 PM. He finished his glass of orange juice, the citrus sharp on his tongue, and gathered his leather weekender while the lounge attendants nodded with the silent, practiced reverence of temple guardians. He walked out, leaving the sanctuary of sweeping wooden ribs and living vertical gardens, and the transition was seamless, a glide from one pressurized atmosphere to another where the air tasted less of oxygen and more of exclusivity.

At Gate 10, the general boarding area was a sea of kinetic activity, a mass of bodies vibrating with the stress of travel, but Terdoo bypassed the queues entirely, slipping into the dedicated lane marked for First and Business Class like a shadow returning to the dark. He approached the podium where the gate agent scanned his pass with a smile that didn't quite reach her eyes, but her voice was pleasant enough.

"Have a wonderful trip to London, Mr. Terdoo."

He walked down the aerobridge.

The slope was gentle.

The noise faded away.

Unlike on other airlines, where he would have ascended to the upper deck, Qantas had positioned its premier cabin in the nose of the main deck—the widest and quietest part of the Airbus A350-1000ULR—and as he stepped onto the aircraft, the Customer Service Manager was waiting. She wore the distinctive uniform splashed with fuchsia and red, a burst of color against the neutral fuselage.

"Good evening, Mr. Terdoo," she said, her tone striking the perfect balance between warmth and distance. "I'm Catherine Smith. Welcome aboard. Let me show you to your suite."

She led him to the left, into the exclusive sanctuary of Zone A, and the cabin revealed itself not as a row of seats but as a collection of private rooms. They stopped at Suite 1A on the port side, a micro-apartment that glowed under the mood lighting with the rich, organic warmth of walnut burl wood and neutral creams. It was a stark contrast to the aggressive bling of the Middle Eastern carriers he usually flew; this was understated Australian luxury, designed by David Caon who had learned directly from the great Marc Newson, a palette of sheepskin and oak that felt more like a home than a machine.

Terdoo stepped inside.
The space was immense.
He felt the solitude.

The dual-zone design was immediately apparent, offering both a fixed eighty-inch flat bed and a separate twenty-two-inch-wide reclining armchair, a configuration that meant he would never have to wait for a seat to convert, never have to choose between rest and alertness. The walls rose fifty-seven inches high, a fortress of privacy, and the thirty-two-inch 4K ultra-HD touchscreen—the largest in the fleet—sat dark and waiting like a monolith.

A flight attendant appeared almost instantly, materializing at his elbow with a silver tray.

"Champagne before we go, Mr. Terdoo? We have the Comtes de Champagne Blanc de Blancs 2008 open."

"I'd prefer a glass of water," Terdoo said, the refusal soft but absolute. "I don't do alcohol."

"Of course."

She placed a small porcelain bowl of warm olives and almonds on the side table, the scent of rosemary faintly perceptible, and vanished, returning seconds later with the water and a warm towel scented with Bulgari fragrance.

"We also have your Martin Grant pajamas and amenity kit here," she said softly, placing the items on the ottoman. "We'll be pushing back right on schedule at 8:00 PM. Can I get you anything else before we close up?"

"No, thank you," he replied.

Terdoo took a sip of the water, the cool liquid cutting through the lingering fatigue of the day, and he pressed a button on the control console.

The electronic doors slid shut.
The latch clicked.
He was alone.

The sliding privacy door created a hermetically sealed haven, shielding him from the movement of the crew and the gaze of the other five passengers. He sat in the armchair, the lush upholstery soft against his back, and adjusted the temperature and humidity on the personal interface, crafting a micro-climate that existed only for him. At exactly 8:00 PM, a subtle vibration ran through the floor as the tug engaged, and the massive aircraft began its slow reverse into the darkness of the tarmac.

The cabin lights dimmed to a starry night sky effect, the ceiling becoming a planetarium of artificial constellations, but outside, the groundscape was a galaxy of amber and white LEDs blurring in the rain.

Ping-ping.

The soft two-tone chime sounded through the cabin, and Catherine Smith's voice flowed over the PA, clear and carrying a current of professional gravity.

"Good evening, ladies and gentlemen, and welcome to a defining moment in aviation history. Welcome aboard Qantas flight QF1. Tonight, we are redefining the iconic Kangaroo Route. For the first time ever, we are connecting Sydney to London in a single continuous flight, making this the longest commercial service in the world. We will be in the air for approximately twenty-three hours, bypassing our traditional stopover in Singapore to take you straight to the UK."

Terdo listened to the announcement, watching the raindrops streak horizontally across the glass as the aircraft taxied. The audio crackled, and a new voice took over—deep, authoritative, the voice of a man who held the lives of over two hundred and fifty people in his hands.

"G'day everyone, this is **Captain Adam Duncan Kent** speaking from the flight deck. I want to personally welcome you to this milestone flight. We are fully fueled and ready to push the limits of what is possible in commercial aviation. Our flight plan tonight is unique. To make this non-stop sector possible, we will not be taking the traditional northern track over Asia. Instead, we will be flying an 'Arctic Loop' that tracks North-Northeast across the Pacific."

The Captain's voice was smooth, a calming baritone against the hum of the engines.

"We will track past Japan and the Aleutian Islands, cross the Bering Strait to chase the rising sun, and then navigate directly over the North Pole before descending through the Polar Night of the High Arctic toward London. This 'top-of-the-world' corridor, combined with specific high-latitude headwinds, brings our total flight time to twenty-three hours. Because we are carrying maximum fuel for this ultra-long-range sector, our aircraft is exceptionally heavy. You will notice a longer-than-usual takeoff roll on Runway 34 Left before we get airborne. Sit back, relax, and enjoy the view. We'll see you in London."

Terdo smiled.

He recognized the voice.

The taxi was short.
The engines spooled up.
The power was absolute.

A deep, rising thrum pressed Terdoo gently into his leather seat, the sheer size of the A350-1000ULR making the acceleration feel powerful yet incredibly stable, the aura of a leviathan waking up. They thundered down the tarmac, the runway lights flashing past like strobe lights, until the earth let go of the wheels.

They lifted off.

Immediately, the dark waters of Botany Bay fell away, a void of black ink replaced by the glittering grid of the southern suburbs. As the aircraft climbed and banked sharply to the right, the large window frame filled with a scene of breathtaking, industrial beauty.

Sydney at night was a masterpiece of electricity and geography, a sprawling circuit board of life. The dense cluster of the CBD skyscrapers stood like shards of gold and sapphire against the black velvet of the night, and Terdoo pressed closer to the window, his breath misting slightly on the cool glass. There, unmistakable even from this height, was the Sydney Harbour Bridge, a curved coat hanger of steel illuminated in cool grey light. Beneath it, the Opera House shells glowed a pearlescent white, looking like tiny, discarded sails on the edge of the harbour's inky expanse.

The ferries were small specks of light cutting wake trails through the water, moving between the neon vibrancy of Circular Quay and the darkened North Shore, and the aircraft continued its banking turn, sweeping panoramically from the city to the eastern suburbs, where the golden streetlights met the abrupt, dark void of the Pacific Ocean.

For a few seconds, the entire basin was visible.
Millions of lives played out below.
He was untouchable.

Then the A350-1000ULR leveled out and pierced a thin layer of clouds, turning the view into a soft, glowing haze. Terdoo exhaled, the sound loud in the enclosed suite, and he reclined his seat, the image of the burning harbour scorched into his retinas as he prepared for the long, suspended luxury of the flight ahead. But even as the city vanished, he felt a prickle on the back of his neck, a phantom sensation that he wasn't quite as alone on this flight as the closed doors suggested.

Chapter 2

Over the Coral Sea

Date: 12th February, 2027

Time: 9:00 PM (Sydney) / 10:00 AM (London)

The cabin was a pressurized capsule of manufactured night, hurtling through the stratosphere at six hundred miles an hour, and while the rest of the world slept beneath the blanket of the Outback darkness, **Terdoo** sat in the golden glow of his reading lamp, the nib of his fountain pen scratching a rhythmic, solitary line across the paper of his journal. *The silence is a physical weight.* He had synced his phone to the suite's entertainment system, and the afro-beats of Davido's "*If*" pulsed softly through the noise-canceling headphones, a bassline that vibrated against his jawbone and anchored him to a rhythm that felt like home. But across the aisle, separated by the vacuum of the empty middle suite, **Jewel** was vibrating with a frequency that threatened to crack the fuselage.

She had tried to watch a movie, but the screen felt like a dead eye staring back at her, and the solitude of Suite 1K, which should have been a luxury, felt like a cage designed to amplify the static in her head. *I cannot be alone with my own thoughts.* The guilt about the ring in her bag and the man in London was a low-level nausea in her stomach, so she unbuckled her belt, the metal click sounding like a gunshot in the quiet cabin, and slid the heavy privacy door open.

She stepped into the aisle.

The air was cold.

She walked toward the galley.

She didn't know where she was going, only that she needed movement, but as she passed the open door of Suite 1A, a voice stopped her—low, baritone, and cool as the air conditioning vents above them.

"I'll have the Wagyu fried rice," Terdoo said, not looking up from his journal.
"Chimichurri sauce. Truffle mashed potatoes on the side. And a bottle of coconut water."

Diane, the flight attendant who had welcomed them aboard, was leaning against the doorframe of his suite, her posture curving in a way that was not entirely regulation, a smile playing on her lips that suggested she was offering more than just the menu.

"And to drink? Perhaps the Comtes de Champagne again?" she asked, her voice dropping an octave.

"No alcohol," Terdoo replied, his tone polite but final, a door closing gently in her face.
"Just the water. Thank you, Diane."

Diane straightened up, the professional mask sliding back into place as she turned to leave, and she brushed past **Jewel**, leaving a scent of frustration and expensive hairspray in her wake. Jewel stood there for a moment, the hum of the engines filling the silence, and then, driven by an impulse she couldn't name—a magnetic pull toward the void—she stepped into the doorway of Suite 1A.

Terdoo stopped writing.
He felt the intrusion.
He looked up.

For a second, the only sound was the Davido track playing faintly from both the speakers and headphones, and **Jewel** felt the air leave her lungs in a rush because, now that he wasn't wearing sunglasses, his eyes were devastating—dark, intelligent, and looking at her with a mixture of confusion and mild annoyance.

"You're here," she said, the words tumbling out before she could check them. "You gave me your ticket, but you're... here."

"I am," Terdoo said, and he didn't close the journal or invite her in.

"But the flight was full," she insisted, leaning against the walnut paneling, her presence filling the doorway with a riot of color and energy that clashed beautifully with the neutral tones of the suite. "How?"

Terdoosighed, a sound that was less about fatigue and more about the realization that his solitude had been breached.

"I am trying to have dinner," he said, and his gaze drifted back to the page. "If I answer honestly, will you leave?"

"Maybe," Jewel laughed, and the sound was a sudden, bright chime that cut through the recycled air. "If the story is interesting."

Terdooslooked at her then, really looked at her, and the pen paused in his hand. *She is a kaleidoscope.* She was wearing a custom Julia Heur dress, a chaotic masterpiece of sensuous colors and unorthodox patterns that seemed to shift under the mood lighting, paired with tan Harley Davidson Lorene 14 cowboy boots that added a rugged, grounded weight to her ethereal height. A denim jacket was tied around her waist, cinching the fabric, and her red hair flowed over her shoulders like liquid copper. She stood five-foot-nine, tall and imposing, and her brown eyes were wide, challenging him to be boring.

She is weird, he thought, the corner of his mouth twitching against his will. *And she is beautiful.*

"I bought all the First-Class suites," Terdoo said, his voice flat, delivering the absurdity as a simple fact. "A year ago. When the flight was announced."

Jewel blinked.

Her mouth opened slightly.

She sat on the edge of his bed.

"No way," she breathed, leaning in, her earlier hesitation evaporating completely. "You bought... the whole cabin?"

"I kept three for myself," he continued, watching the way she made herself at home in his sanctuary. "I write better in the air. And I wanted to see the double sunrise. One from the left side of the aircraft, and one from the right. It requires a suite on both sides."

Jewel stared at him, the sheer extravagance of the statement warring with the poetry of it. *He had spent a fortune not for status, but for the sun.*

"How much?" she asked.

"One hundred thousand pounds. Each."

She laughed again, thinking it was a joke, but his face remained a mask of calm seriousness, and the laughter died in her throat, replaced by a sudden, intense curiosity that made her skin prickle. "And the others? You said you kept three. Who is in the rest?"

"I gifted them," Terdoo said, finally closing his journal. "To friends."

"Who?" she demanded, her eyes wide.

He gestured vaguely over his shoulder toward the suite behind him. "Prince William is in 2A. We are friends."

Jewel's head whipped around to stare at the wall separating them from the future King of England, and when she turned back, her expression was a mix of horror and delight.

"And the middle?"

"Bruno Mars," Terdoo said. "He had a show in Sydney and needs to be in London for Valentine's Day. I admire his work. He, Chris Brown, Ed Sheeran... they are the greatest of a generation."

"And the last one?" she pressed, pointing to the final suite.

"That," Terdoo said, "is a secret."

Diane appeared then, carrying a tray laden with the smell of truffles and rich beef, and Terdoo moved to clear his table, expecting Jewel to take the hint and retreat to her side of the plane. But Jewel turned to the hostess, her smile blinding and conspiratorial.

"Diane, could you bring my dinner here, please?" Jewel asked. "We're eating together."

Terdoo choked.
He grabbed his water.
He coughed violently.

He looked at her, his eyes wide with a question he didn't ask, but she simply settled back against the pillows of his bed, crossing her booted legs. "I never eat alone," she said, and the vulnerability in her voice was so slight, so carefully hidden, that he almost missed it.

He didn't argue. He simply nodded to Diane, who looked flustered but hurried away to comply.

They ate in a silence that was surprisingly comfortable, the clinking of silverware the only punctuation in the conversation. Terdoo watched as she demolished an order that would have felled a lesser woman—caviar appetizers, followed by a Filet Mignon, sauteed mushrooms, and then, to his utter baffled amusement, two cheeseburgers for dessert.

"You ordered wine," she noted, pointing to the glass Diane had brought for him by mistake. "But you don't drink."

"You can have it," he said.

She took the glass, her fingers brushing the stem, and drained half of it in one swallow. She watched him eat his rice, noting the precise way he mixed the chimichurri, and she listened to the faint beat of Davido still leaking from his headphones on the table.

"You're Nigerian," she said suddenly.

Terdoo paused, a forkful of truffle mash halfway to his mouth. "How could you possibly know that?"

"The rice," she listed, ticking off fingers. "The Davido track. The casual way you spent half a million pounds on airplane seats. And the fact that you're eating that spicy sauce without flinching."

Terdoo looked at her, and for the first time, the "Cold Void" he carried around his chest felt a hairline fracture. She was observant. She was intrusive. She was eating a cheeseburger in a couture dress next to Prince William.

"Half Nigerian," he corrected softly.

"It counts," she grinned.

She finished her wine, placing the empty glass down on the tray with a decisive click, and looked at him with a sweetness that felt dangerous, a soft, innocent expression that made the air in the suite feel suddenly thin.

"This counts, you know," she whispered.

"Counts as what?"

"Our first date."

Terdoo felt the words land in the center of his chest like a heavy stone. He opened his mouth to dismiss it, to tell her that dates were for people with futures, not for ghosts like him, but she didn't give him the chance. She didn't stand up. She didn't smooth her dress and leave.

Instead, she kicked off her boots.

She curled her legs up onto the ottoman at the end of his suite, pulling the heavy sheepskin duvet over her lap as if she had lived there for years, nesting into the corner of his solitude.

"Goodnight, stranger," she murmured, her eyes fluttering shut.

Terdoo sat frozen, his hand hovering over his journal. He looked at the woman invading his sanctuary, at the chaotic beauty of her dress now still under the blanket, and he felt the old walls slam down, steel and concrete rising up to protect the soft parts of him he thought he had buried. But he didn't ask her to leave. He simply turned down the brightness of his reading lamp, casting them both in shadow.

"My name is Terdoo," he said, the words quiet but distinct in the hushed cabin. "My acquaintances can call me Tay."

He chose the word carefully—*acquaintances*—a verbal line drawn in the sand to keep her at a distance, to remind her that sharing a meal did not mean sharing a soul.

Jewel shifted under the duvet, a sleepy smile touching her lips, her voice weak and fading into the hum of the engines.

"My stage name is Jewel," she whispered, "but my close friends call me Juliet."

The silence returned, heavier than before. She offered him friendship; he offered her acquaintance. She slept; he watched.

Love is not in the cards, he told himself, the thought a familiar mantra. *Not for you. Never again.*

But as the aircraft suspended itself between two continents and the clock ticked toward the next hour out of the twenty-one more for this flight, he realized with a sudden, jarring clarity that there was no easy way to avoid someone while in a box flying through the sky—and she wasn't going anywhere.

Chapter 3

Near Solomon Islands

Date: 12th February, 2027

Time: 10:00 PM (Sydney) / 11:00 AM (London)

The aircraft was a silver needle threading the gap between the earth and the stars, and Terdoo sat in the shadowed corner of Suite 1A, watching the coastline of Western Australia drift by like a smudge of charcoal on a canvas of deep indigo. *This is the only peace I know.* The vibration of the engines was a constant, low-frequency hum that settled into his marrow, a sensation of stability that the ground never seemed to offer him, and he turned his gaze from the window to the bed where the intruder was finally silent.

Jewel was asleep.

She lay fully stretched out on the flatbed, her limbs loose and heavy with the red wine and the altitude, and the sheepskin duvet had slipped down, leaving her shoulders exposed to the refrigerated air of the cabin. She looked almost magical in the dim light, her red hair fanning out across the white pillowcase like a spilled fire, and her bare feet peeked out from the bottom of the covers, vulnerable and pale. Terdoo watched her, feeling the familiar tightening in his chest, a defensive reflex against the sheer, chaotic beauty she brought into his ordered world. He stood up, moving silently on the carpet, and picked up the spare blanket from the overhead bin, draping it gently over her shoulders.

He paused.

He stared.

He couldn't look away.

She breathed in, a soft, hitching sound, and he felt a sudden, terrifying urge to smooth a stray lock of hair from her forehead. *You are losing your mind.* The thought was sharp, a slap to the face, and he recoiled, grabbing his leather journal, his fountain pen, and his phone. He needed a wall. He needed a door.

He backed out of Suite 1A, sliding the privacy door shut with a soft click that sealed her in, and crossed the aisle to the empty center suite, 1F—the buffer zone he had purchased for exactly this kind of retreat.

Inside 1F, the lighting was brighter, a clinical white that banished the shadows. Terdoo sat in the armchair, adjusted the volume on his phone where "*Why*" by Poet in process was playing—a melancholic, searching track that seemed to ask the questions he refused to voice—and kept the volume low, a ghost of a melody, remembering subconsciously how easily she had stirred in the other room. He opened his journal. He uncapped his pen. He tried to write, but the ink refused to flow.

Knock. Knock.

The sound was light, tentative, barely audible over the music.

Terdoo checked his watch. It had been ten minutes. *Diane again*. He assumed the flight attendant was back to check on the "couple" or offer more water, so he stood up, his expression arranging itself into a mask of polite dismissal, and slid the door open.

It wasn't Diane.

Jewel stood in the aisle, the spare blanket wrapped tight around her shoulders like a cape, her bare feet sinking into the plush carpet. Her eyes were heavy-lidded, glazed with sleep and the lingering effects of the Shiraz, looking up at him with the unguarded innocence of a child who had woken up from a nightmare.

"Why are you awake?" Terdoo asked, his hand gripping the doorframe.

"I can't sleep," she mumbled, swaying slightly. "Not when it's so quiet. Not when I'm alone."

She didn't wait for an invitation. She stepped past him, the scent of her perfume—vanilla and something floral—invading his sterile sanctuary, and she climbed onto the bed in Suite 1F, curling up instantly. Terdoo watched her, feeling the "Cold Void" in his chest fracture a little more. He should tell her to go back. He should call the attendant. Instead, he sighed, defeated, and moved to the armchair. He dimmed the lights down to a warm amber, turning the music down until it was just a heartbeat in the background.

"So," Terdoo said, watching her settle. "What happens on your next international flight? Do you break into the suite of another strange man and steal his blankets?"

The thought tasted like bile in his throat—a sharp, acidic flare of something that felt dangerously like possessiveness.

"I am this way with you because I can't control it," Jewel said, her voice slurring slightly, stripped of all inhibition. "I feel like I've known you forever. It's weird."

She shifted, pulling the blanket to her chin.

"If you let me, I can take you on every tour and show I have to attend," she added shamelessly, a sleepy smile playing on her lips. "That way I won't be with any strangers. And I won't suffer insomnia."

"How do you normally sleep?" he asked, genuinely curious. "When you don't have a stranger to harass?"

"Caesar," she murmured. "The airlines in the States let me buy a ticket for him. He sleeps right here." She patted the empty space beside her.

"Caesar?" Terdoo raised an eyebrow. "You have a man you normally travel with?"

"A Rottweiler," she corrected, giggling softly. "He is big and beautiful and very good at cuddling."

"I see."

"And..." she hesitated, the smile faltering slightly. "I have a man. In London."

The air in the suite seemed to drop ten degrees. Terdoo sat very still, his pen hovering over the paper. *Of course she does.* The realization hit him with the force of a physical blow to the ribs, a dull ache spreading through his chest.

"He was supposed to be here," Jewel continued, the words tumbling out in a stream of confession. "In Australia. He was going to propose. But... business. Always business. So he called my manager. We did a video call." She held up her hand, twisting a ring that wasn't there, seemingly forgetting she had packed it away. "I said yes. He bought the ring in Sydney."

"A video call proposal," Terdoo said, his voice flat.

"It's modern," she defended weakly. "Everything can be done across distances now."

"Does he make you happy?"

"I admire him," she said, and the choice of word was telling. "He is a wonderful man. Reliable. A good friend. I never thought I'd marry him, but... he will be a good spouse. I have feelings for him." She paused, her brown eyes searching the ceiling. "I just don't know if it's deep enough. I don't know if it's the kind of love that makes you soulmates."

"What is his name?" Terdoo asked. He was already unlocking his phone.

"Ferdinand Osuna," she yawned. "I call him by his middle name, Jack."

Terdoo typed the name. *Osuna*. He recognized the family—Spanish shipping magnates, old money, powerful connections. He clicked on the Instagram link, and a face filled his screen: handsome, polished, smiling on a yacht in the Mediterranean.

Terdoo looked at the photo.
He looked at his own reflection in the dark window.
I am better looking.

The thought was petty, childish, and entirely beneath him, and he caught himself immediately, a short, dry laugh escaping his throat. *Look at you, Terdoo. Jealous of a man on a screen.*

"He is a lucky man," Terdoo said quietly, locking the phone and placing it face down. "I wonder if he knows just how lucky."

Jewel turned her head on the pillow to look at him. "Do you believe in true love, Tay? Love at first sight?"

"I have experienced true love once," Terdoo replied, the memory a ghost brushing against his skin. "But love at first sight? I don't know if it is realistic to be sure about love just by seeing someone. You need to know a person."

"Then open up," she whispered, her voice heavy with sleep. "Let people get to know you, Mr. Tay."

Terdoo looked at her, at the way the amber light softened the curve of her cheek.

"If he is Jack," Terdoo said, a small smirk touching his lips, "then your name should have been Rose. Not Jewel."

Her eyes fluttered open, struggling against the weight of exhaustion.

"You should be on a ship," he added, chuckling at his own wit, "instead of the longest flight in the world."

Jewel smiled, a slow, lazy curving of her lips that made his breath hitch.

"I am Juliet," she corrected softly, her voice gaining a moment of clarity. "Not Rose. So hopefully... I find my Romeo."

The name hung in the air.

Romeo.

Juliet.

Terdoo froze. The laughter died in his throat, replaced by a shock so profound it felt like the floor of the aircraft had dropped out from under him. He looked at her, really looked at her, and the pieces of the puzzle slammed together with a violence that left him reeling. The "impossible" nature of their meeting, the timing, the names—it wasn't just coincidence. It felt like a script written in invisible ink that he was only just now reading. *The hand of fate is not gentle*, he thought. *It is a hammer.*

He looked at the woman lying in his bed, this radiant chaos who had broken into his solitude and his fortress, and he decided, in that singular moment of clarity, that he would not be a coward. Not tonight.

"Jewel," he said.

"Hmm?"

"Are you hungry?"

"Always," she murmured.

"Then wake up," he said, his voice firm. "Let's go to the bar. Let's have an actual date. Before we try to sleep for real."

Jewel sat up.
Her eyes snapped wide open.
The sleep vanished.

She looked at him, a wide, incredulous grin spreading across her face, and she threw the blanket off.

"Now?" she asked.

"Now," Terdoo said, checking his watch. It was a few minutes past 11:00 PM. "The night is young."

He stood up and offered her his hand. She took it, and the contact sent that same electric jolt up his arm, a warning and a promise all at once. They were walking into dangerous territory, leaving the safety of the suites for the open exposure of the bar, but as he pulled her to her feet, Terdoo realized he was looking forward to it.

Chapter 4

North Pacific (equator)

Date: 12th February, 2027

Time: 11:00 PM (Sydney) / 12:00 PM (London)

The dedicated lounge galley was a marvel of physics and intimacy, a pocket of warmth carved out of the cold aluminum ribs of the fuselage. It was designed as a self-serve oasis for the restless souls of Business and First Class, featuring sleek modular trolleys secured with industrial locks to prevent the premium Australian Shiraz from obeying gravity during turbulence, and a fridge that hummed with the promise of midnight snacks. The space was compact, seating only eight passengers on plush leather banquettes, but it felt expansive, a floating jazz club suspended thirty-five thousand feet above the black expanse of the Indian Ocean.

Terdoo sat at the small bar counter, his navy jacket abandoned in the suite, wearing only his white t-shirt and the loose lounge trousers provided by the airline, his feet clad in the complimentary slippers. He held his phone in one hand, staring at the screen with a mixture of polite detachment and a deep, gnawing distaste.

The video is looped.

It was Jewel's proposal. The video, reposted by a gossip blog, showed her manager holding up a tablet while a pixelated man—Ferdinand Osuna—asked a question that changed the trajectory of a life. Jewel looked happy in the clip, crying into her hands, but Terdoo watched her eyes. *She is performing happiness.* He tried to feel happy for her, to be the good man he pretended to be, but the feeling in his gut was heavy, like swallowed lead.

"It shows in the eyes, mate," a voice said, rough and warm like old leather.

Terdoo looked up. **John**, a man with a shock of grey hair and lines etched deep into a face that had seen more sunsets than most people had seen breakfasts, was wiping down the already pristine counter.

"I didn't think this bar had staff," Terdoo said, locking his phone and sliding it face down. "It's self-serve."

"It is," John replied, his Australian accent thick and comforting. "But serving drinks is an occupation of the soul. I've been doing it for five decades. Never took a break. I wasn't going to miss the chance to go down in history as the barman on the longest flight in the world."

Terdoo smiled, a genuine expression that reached his eyes. He appreciated passion, especially when it was quiet and steadfast. "That is commendable, John. To witness history."

"I witness more than history," John said, leaning forward on his elbows. "I've been a barman long enough to be a therapist, a priest, and a judge. I've given advice to every type of man and woman on this spinning globe. So, tell me. What is weighing on you?"

Terdoo sighed, running a hand through his hair. The honesty of the stranger was disarming.

"I am conflicted," Terdoo admitted, the words feeling foreign on his tongue. "I feel things for someone I shouldn't. And the pain of a loss... it still eats at me. It makes me feel I have no right to want anything new."

John nodded slowly, as if he had expected this answer.

"*Amor fati*," John murmured. "Love your fate. Which is, in fact, your life." He paused, looking at the bottles secured behind the wire mesh. "Is she taken?"

"She is engaged," Terdoo whispered.

"Love happens exactly where it is meant to happen," John said, his voice dropping to a conspiratorial whisper. "It makes no mistakes. Look over there."

He gestured with his chin toward the corner banquette. **Ben and Bea**, a young couple with tangled limbs and eyes only for each other, were giggling over a shared bag of chips.

"Her father is a Duke," John whispered. "Old English nobility. Stiff upper lip and all that. He is the son of their housekeeper. By all accounts, they shouldn't exist. But they fell in love, ran off to Australia, and he built a life for them. Now they are flying back to London to face the music. He doesn't need to do that, but he is doing it for her."

Terdoo watched them. They looked terrified and invincible all at once.

"When you feel it," John said, meeting Terdoo's eyes, "you go all in. Or you spend the rest of your life wondering."

They shook hands across the bar, a firm grip of understanding, just as the air in the lounge shifted.

Jewel appeared.

She had changed into a black dress that clung to her frame like a second skin, elegant and dangerous, but her feet were clad in the same airline slippers, and her red hair flowed free, a chaotic halo around her face. She looked like a queen who had just rolled out of bed, and Terdoo felt his heart stutter in his chest.

"I have one important first date question," Terdoo said immediately, before she could sit down. "Are you a Krum or an Ellingboe?"

Jewel blinked, stopping mid-step. "A what?"

"It is a concept from *Klaus*," Terdoo explained, his face serious. "Released in 2019. My favorite Christmas movie. It touches on the beauty of humanity in a way that is touching, explaining the origins of Santa Claus through a feud between two clans—the Krums and the Ellingboes."

Jewel laughed, the sound bright and uninhibited. "You are passionate about a cartoon?"

"It is cinema, I am passionate about all cinema" Terdoo corrected gently. "I suspect, with your red hair and your free spirit, I already know the answer."

"I promise to watch it," she grinned, sliding onto the stool next to him.

"Why are you here?" she asked, her tone shifting, probing. "Why fly to Australia just to turn around and fly back to London before Valentine's? You aren't wearing a ring."

"I signed a business deal," Terdoo said. "But the main reason was the flight itself. I love aviation. Spending hours in the air is the only time I feel completely free. And the double sunrise... witnessing it twice in one day is rare magic. It just happened to coincide with an important wedding I must attend in London."

He turned the question back on her. "And you? You seemed unaware this was a record-breaking flight."

"Money," Jewel shrugged, though there was a professional pride in her voice. "My manager got a gig in London. A huge fan offered to pay even more than the Australian show I just headlined. I couldn't say no. I needed to be in London early to rehearse. They are paying for perfection, so I must give them the absolute best."

"Is there a reason why you hate small spaces?" Terdoo asked, the transition sudden but necessary. "Why you can't sleep alone?"

The smile slipped from her face for a second.

"When I was thirteen," she said, her voice quiet. "I was kidnapped. Locked in a van in a parking lot for three days. Some men... I guess it had to do with my father being a judge. I don't know the details. But silence... silence feels like that van."

Terdoo reached out.
He placed his hand over hers on the counter.
He didn't speak.

He just squeezed her hand, a silent anchor, sadness washing over him that something so vibrant had been caged. She looked at him, surprised by the warmth, and then smiled, squeezing back.

"We haven't properly introduced ourselves," Terdoo said, lifting the mood with effort. "I am Terdoo King Yimam."

Jewel's eyes widened. "Yimam? As in the real estate Yimams? The ones who own half of London?"

"Yes," he said.

"I should have known," she shook her head. "Buying all the First-Class seats... it screams old money."

"Correction," Terdoo said, raising a finger. "My education and allowances until I was twenty were from them. But my conglomerate? My publishing company? That was built from scratch. My wealth is my own."

"How?" she asked, leaning in.

"That is a story for another time," he deflected smoothly. "But my family... my parents are clergies. The real estate was a side project that exploded. We thank God. I am not the only one," Terdoo added, his tone softening with pride. "I have an elder sister, Gem—she owns the cosmetics brand *Gemstone Beauty*, which you might know. She is happily married with two children. And my younger sister, Queen, works with the United Nations and is getting married soon." He paused, a faint smile touching his lips as a memory surfaced. "We also grew up with a Rottweiler named Alpha and a tuxedo cat named Lady. So, believe me when I say I understand the bond. Your Caesar would love me, and I would love him."

"A typical Nigerian answer," Jewel teased. "Everything is 'We thank God'."

"I am only half Nigerian," Terdoo reminded her. "I have the determination, smarts, and adaptability of the Nigerian side. But not the over-reliance on the supernatural to fix things that require action, like bad governance. And I have the politeness, charm, and leadership of the English side. But not the disregard for other cultures."

Jewel nodded, impressed. "So you took the best and left the worst."

"Ideally," he smiled. "And you? What is the bad thing about being American?"

"I know how to use a gun," she said flatly.

Terdoo smiled. "And the good quality?"

"I know how to *really* use a gun," she replied, a mischievous glint in her brown eyes.

They both burst out laughing, a genuine, shared sound that made John chuckle from behind the bar.

"John," Terdoo said, wiping a tear from his eye. "We are thirsty."

"Bellini for the lady," Jewel ordered.

"Kombucha for me," Terdoo added.

John slid the drinks across the counter along with a bowl of olives. Jewel picked up a green olive, tossed it high into the recycled air, and caught it perfectly in her mouth.

Clap. Clap. Clap.

Terdoo laughed, clapping loudly, joined by Ben and Bea from the corner. Jewel bowed theatrically, her hair falling over her face. She did it two more times, missing nothing.

She is amazing, Terdoo thought, watching her flushed face. *Intoxicating.*

She sipped her Bellini, then looked at his fermented tea. "Why don't you drink?" she asked, her voice softer now. "You ordered coconut water earlier and declined the wine."

The laughter faded from Terdoo's face, replaced by a shadow that not even the bar lights could chase away.

"The last time I drank," he said, staring into his glass. "There was an accident. Someone I cared about got hurt. Because of me."

He didn't offer more. Jewel didn't ask. She simply reached over, took his glass of Kombucha, and took a sip, sharing his burden in the only way she could.

"Why don't we have deeper conversations now?" she suggested, placing the glass back between them. "We still have some time."

Terdoo looked at her, at the woman who could use a gun and catch olives and feared the silence.

"I've been waiting for that."

Chapter 5

North Pacific Ocean

Date: 13th February, 2027

Time: 12:30 AM (Sydney) / 1:30 PM (London)

The playlist Terdoo had requested shifted, the algorithms of the entertainment system dissolving the previous silence into the chaotic, vibrant energy of Remi Wolf's "*Soup*," a track that bounced off the curved walls of the fuselage with a frenetic, disco-pop heartbeat. It was a loop of organized noise that seemed to mirror the woman sitting next to him. Jewel sat on the high leather stool, her black dress slipping slightly off one shoulder in a way that was entirely accidental yet devastatingly precise, and she swirled the melting ice in her Bellini, the glass chiming softly against her rings.

Terdoo watched her. Without the heavy barrier of his navy jacket, the white T-shirt he wore was less of a garment and more of a revelation, the cotton clinging to his frame and revealing arms that were unexpectedly corded with muscle—not the vanity muscle of a man who spent hours staring at himself in a gym mirror, but the dense, functional strength of a man who carried heavy burdens, perhaps physical, perhaps spiritual, for far too long.

He is solid, she thought, her eyes lingering on the line of his forearm as he rested it on the polished counter. *A rock in the middle of a rushing stream. And I am tired of swimming.*

"I have done my research," Terdoo said, his voice low and rhythmic, cutting through the upbeat track like a cello in a pop song. "As a writer, I spend my life categorizing human tragedy. I study why things break. And I have concluded there are seven specific fracture points. Seven things that, when left in the dark, will rot the foundation of any relationship or friendship."

Jewel looked up, intrigued, the playful glint returning to her eyes. "Seven deadly sins?"

"Seven necessary conversations," he corrected, tapping his finger on the cool granite. "I want your honest view on each. We are different people, Jewel. We come from different worlds. I want to see where the bridges are, and where the water is too deep to cross."

"A genius idea," she replied, a genuine spark lighting up her brown eyes. "A way to dive deep without drowning. To discuss the soul without stepping on the ego."

"I am a writer by trade," Terdoo warned, a small, confident smile touching his lips. "I will make good points. I will be passionate. But I am smart enough to listen, and I am humble enough to change my view if the argument is sound."

Jewel laughed, a sound that blended perfectly with the music, bright and uninhibited. "And I almost went to law school before the music took me. I know how to argue a case, Mr. Tay. Especially on things I feel in my bones."

1. Politics

"Individual freedom," Terdoo started, his expression tightening slightly. "Versus social equality. It is the oldest war. I believe a man must build his own house before he can worry about the village. John Locke argued that the liberty of man is to be under no other legislative power but that established by consent."

"But if the village is burning," Jewel countered, leaning in until he could smell the vanilla of her perfume, "the house will catch fire eventually. You can't be free if your neighbor is in chains. We rise by lifting others, not by building higher walls."

"Socialism implies a trust in the collective that history does not support," Ben piped up from the corner, his arm draped possessively around Bea. He waved his drink in the air. "Give a government power to feed you, you give them power to starve you."

"Oh, hush, Ben," Bea rolled her eyes, slapping his knee affectionately. "You only say that because you hate paying taxes. We are our brother's keeper. It's in the Bible."

"It's in the Quran too, *habibti*," Ben shot back, grinning at her. "But charity is voluntary. Taxes are theft."

John polished a glass behind the bar, the cloth moving in slow, meditative circles, his presence like a calm anchor in the storm of opinions. "The river does not fight the rock," he said softly. "It flows around it. Shared goals, my friends. You both want a safe world. Focus on the community improvement, not the policy writing."

2. Religion

The music shifted again, transitioning into the soaring, gravelly vocals of Sam Ryder's "*More*," the track swelling with a yearning that changed the atmosphere in the lounge instantly, stripping away the playful vibe and replacing it with something heavier.

"Literal versus symbolic," Terdoo moved the topic forward, his voice dropping an octave, becoming intimate. "I was raised in the church. My parents are clergy. I believe in the structure, the history, the discipline. But absolute faith?" He paused, looking down at his hands, his thumbs tracing the line of his knuckles. "Loss has a way of turning absolute truths into metaphors. I struggle to see the literal hand of God in a world that takes the good too young. To me, the text is poetry, not physics."

Jewel shook her head, her expression fierce, her body tense. "It's not poetry to me. It's oxygen. I believe in miracles because I shouldn't be here. I believe God is listening. Even when it hurts. Especially when it hurts. If you treat it as a symbol, you lose the power of the promise."

"But if the promise is broken?" Terdoo asked, a challenge in his eyes, a glimpse of the wound he carried.

"Then you held onto the wrong part of it," she shot back without hesitation, refusing to back down.

Terdoo watched her, noting the set of her jaw, the fire in her eyes. *She is really opinionated*, he thought, a strange mixture of annoyance and admiration curling in his chest. *Just as stubborn as Rosaline*.

3. Morality

"Absolute truths," Terdoo posited, recovering his rhythm. "Kant's categorical imperative. There are things that are right, and things that are wrong, regardless of the context. A lie is a lie, Jewel. Murder is murder."

"Situational," Jewel argued, lifting her glass. "Stealing bread is wrong. Stealing bread to feed a starving child is necessary. Lying to protect someone's feelings is kindness, not sin. Morality is a fluid thing, shaped by the moment and the people involved."

"Compassion is slippery," Terdoo noted. "Honesty is concrete. If we navigate by feelings, we get lost at sea."

"Then let honesty be the compass," John suggested from behind the bar, his Buddhist philosophy offering the middle path. "But let compassion be the wind in the sails. You need both to move."

4. Relationships

"Independence," Terdoo said, and this time he looked directly at Jewel, his gaze heavy. "Versus connection. I need silence. I need a room with a locked door. It is not a rejection; it is a recharge. To love someone is to let them be alone."

"I need noise," Jewel admitted, meeting his gaze, her voice softening. "I need to know someone is there. Independence feels like abandonment to me. If I love you, I want to be in your space. Silence is just distance wearing a mask."

"Clingy," Ben coughed into his drink, earning another elbow from Bea.

"Cold," Bea countered.

"Boundaries," Jewel said, realizing the answer as she spoke, the bridge forming in her mind. "If I know you are coming back, I can let you go. It's the uncertainty that kills me."

"Compromise," Terdoo agreed, nodding slowly. "I will lock the door, but I will give you the key."

5. Parenting

"Strict discipline," Terdoo said. "Structure creates safety. A child needs to know the edges of the world. They need to know that actions have consequences, or they will break themselves against reality later."

"Permissive," Jewel shook her head, her red hair catching the dim light. "Love creates safety. A child needs to know they are accepted, even when they color outside the lines. If you are too hard, they learn to lie, not to behave."

"Our kids are going to be confused," Ben laughed, draining his glass. "Military school or Art school?"

"Both," Bea smirked. "Disciplined artists."

"Discuss the outcome," John advised, bowing slightly. "You both want a good human. The method is secondary to the intention."

6. Money

"Saving for the future," Terdoo said. "Building a fortress. Wealth is security. It is the wall that keeps the chaos out."

"Enjoying the present," Jewel countered. "You can't take it with you. Wealth is fuel for memories. If you build a fortress but never throw a party, you're just a prisoner in a castle."

"Joint budget," Terdoo conceded, seeing the logic in her eyes. "Allocate funds for the fortress, and funds for the fire."

7. Personal Values

"Ambition," Jewel said, the Sam Ryder track reaching its crescendo behind her words, filling the lounge with sound. "I want to touch the sky. I want to leave a mark. I want the world to know I was here."

"Simplicity," Terdoo replied softly. "I want peace. I want a quiet room and a good pen. I want to disappear into the work, not shine in front of it."

They fell silent then. This was the deepest divide. The Radiant Chaos versus the Cold Void. The Star and the Writer.

"Different values can coexist," John said, placing the polished glass down. "The sky needs the earth to look down upon. And the earth needs the sky to look up to. They enrich each other."

Terdoo looked at Jewel. He saw the fire in her, the ambition that drove her, and he realized he didn't want to extinguish it. He wanted to warm his hands by it. And Jewel looked at Terdoo, saw the stillness in him, and realized she didn't want to break it. She wanted to rest in it.

"We agree to disagree," Jewel smiled, but it was a soft, tired smile.

"We agree to understand," Terdoo corrected.

He stood up, the movement fluid, sensing that the moment had reached its natural conclusion. The debate was over, but something far more dangerous had begun. The conversation had stripped away the polite veneer of "acquaintance" and left them standing on the raw ground of true understanding.

"Thank you, John," Terdoo said, nodding to the bartender. "Your wisdom is worth more than the ticket price."

"Safe travels, my friend," John replied, offering a bow. "May you find what you are looking for."

Terdoo turned to the corner booth. "Ben, Bea. Try to get some sleep. You have parents to face in London."

"Goodnight, mate!" Ben called out, sleepy but happy. "Good luck with the writing."

"Goodnight, you two," Bea added, waving a hand. "You look good together."

Jewel blushed, a heat rising to her cheeks that had nothing to do with the Bellini, but she stood up, sliding off the stool. Her adrenaline was fading, leaving her feeling heavy and exposed, stripped raw by the honesty of the last hour. Terdoo didn't just walk away; he waited for her, offering his arm not as a prop, but as an anchor. She hesitated for only a fraction of a second before slipping her hand into the crook of his elbow.

They walked down the quiet aisle of the First Class cabin, the carpet absorbing their footsteps, the only sound the muffled roar of the wind outside. It felt less like a walk to a seat and more like the end of a long date, the walk to the doorstep where the air is thick with things unsaid.

They stopped at **Suite 1K**—her suite.

Terdoo reached out and slid the door open for her. He stood at the threshold, keeping that respectful distance, but his eyes held hers, dark and unreadable. The "Tay" who kept people at arm's length was gone; the "Terdoo" who had debated philosophy and shared his fears stood in his place.

"Goodnight, Juliet," he said softly.

The use of the name hit her like a physical touch. He wasn't calling her by her stage name, or the name she gave strangers. He was calling her by the name she had given him in the dark, the name that implied a tragic, fated connection. He was acknowledging the intimacy of the last hour. He was letting her in.

Jewel looked up at him, her heart hammering against her ribs. To call him "Tay" now would be a lie. It would be a shield she no longer had the strength to hold up.

"Goodnight, Terdoo," she whispered, her voice trembling.

He held her gaze for one second longer—a second that stretched into an eternity—before he nodded once, turned, and walked away toward the other side of the plane, toward his own solitude in Suite 1A.

Jewel pressed the button to close the door.

The latch clicked.

She was alone.

She didn't move toward the bed. Instead, she sank to the floor, her black dress pooling around her like ink, and pulled her knees to her chest. The silence of the suite rushed in to fill the space where his voice had been, and she felt a physical ache in the center of her chest, a tightening that had nothing to do with the altitude.

She thought of Ferdinand in London, safe and predictable.
She thought of Terdoo, deep and terrifyingly real.

She rested her forehead against her knees, the realization settling over her like a cold shroud. He had let her in. She had let him in. And that was the problem.

I have to let him go.

She just wasn't sure which "Him" she meant anymore.

Chapter 6

Suite 1K, *North pacific ocean*

Date: 13th February, 2027

Time: 1:30 AM (Sydney) / 2:30 PM (London)

The floor of Suite 1K was cold, but the realization that she had to let him go was colder. Juliet stood up, her joints popping with the stiffness of emotional resignation, and shed the black dress that had felt like armor only an hour ago. She slipped into the Martin Grant pajama set provided by the airline, the navy cotton soft and forgiving against her skin, and felt a sudden, childish need to be somewhere that smelled like rain and old paper.

She walked across the aisle.
She knocked on the door of Suite 1A.
Silence answered.

She slid the door open, expecting to see him writing, but the suite was empty. The reading light was still on, casting a golden halo over the unmade bed, and his phone sat on the side table, connected to the speakers. Sishii's *"Mbali"* played softly, a soulful, rhythmic plea that filled the empty room with a haunting presence, but the man himself was gone. His journal lay closed on the duvet, a silent sentinel.

She checked the restroom. Empty.
She checked Suite 1F, the central buffer zone. Dark and void.

Panic, irrational and sharp, pricked at her throat. *Where does a man go when there is nowhere to go?* She turned on her heel, the Martin Grant slippers shuffling on the carpet, and headed back toward the lounge, thinking perhaps he had returned for water, or silence, or to finish the conversation they had started.

But the bar was empty, save for **John**.

The grey-haired bartender was sitting on one of the banquettes, watching the silent news on the monitor, looking less like a staff member and more like a weary guardian of the night. He looked up as she entered, his eyes crinkling at the corners.

"He isn't here, darling," John said gently, reading the question before she asked it.

Juliet sank onto the bench opposite him, pulling her knees up. "Love is strange, John. Isn't it?"

"It is the strangest thing we do," John agreed, turning his gaze back to the flight map on the screen. "We spend our lives building walls to keep people out, and then we panic when someone finally finds the door."

"I was trying to find him," she whispered. "I was trying to... I don't know. Fix it. End it. Start it."

"You can't find it while you are actively searching for it," John said, his voice dropping to that therapeutic timbre he had honed over five decades. "It's like looking for your glasses when they are on your head. The frantic energy blinds you."

He leaned forward, and for a moment, the way the dim light caught his face reminded her so viscerally of her father—the Judge, the man she hadn't spoken to in weeks—that her breath hitched. It was the same look of patience, the same absolute certainty that the world had rules, and those rules could be trusted.

"Do the right thing," John advised. "Not just for you, Juliet. But for the people who might be affected if you do the wrong thing. Integrity is a quiet pillow."

"I don't know what the right thing is," she admitted.

"Yes, you do," John smiled, a warm expression that thawed the ice in her chest. "What's yours will come to you. Go to where it is supposed to find you, and wait there. Don't search for it. It always comes to us right where we should be."

Go to where it is supposed to find you.

The epiphany was quiet, not a lightning bolt but a sunrise. She didn't need to chase him through the plane. She didn't need to hunt him down to explain herself. She just needed to be in the place where she belonged.

"Thank you, John," she said, standing up.

"Sleep well, Juliet," he replied.

She walked back to the cabin, her steps lighter now. She went straight to Suite 1A. She didn't hesitate. She climbed into the unmade bed, surrounded by the scent of him—woodsmoke and clean laundry—and pulled the duvet up to her chin. She couldn't drift off, her mind still humming with the vibration of the engines, wondering where exactly Terdoo had gone when they were thirty-five thousand feet in the air, but she lay there, a fixed point in a moving world, waiting to be found.

Time: 1:47 AM

The door to Suite 1A slid open slowly.

Terdoo stood in the threshold, wearing the matching Martin Grant long-sleeved pajamas, the most comfortable things he had ever worn, and looked at the bed. Juliet was there, curled up under his duvet, her red hair spilling over his pillow.

He smiled.

Why am I not surprised?

He stepped inside and closed the door, sealing them in.

He had tried to avoid her. He had left the phone and the journal—his shields—and walked back through the curtain into the Economy cabin, seeking the noise and the friction of the real world. He had found **Ben** and **Bea** in their row, awake and giggling, and he had sat with them, knees pressed against the seat back, listening to their story of running away, of defying dukes and housekeepers. He had learned their fears and their jokes, and for an hour, he wasn't the billionaire with the grief; he was just a man in pajamas listening to love stories.

Three new friends in one day, he thought, adjusting the suite lighting to the dimmest amber setting. *I am breaking all my own rules.*

He needed to clear his mind, and the chaos of the economy cabin had done it. He felt settled. He felt ready.

He picked up his phone from the side table, disconnected the speakers, and reduced the volume. He scrolled through his library, his thumb hovering over the screen as he curated a new playlist—seven songs, a digital mixtape for the sleeping woman. He selected them with the precision of a surgeon:

1. *Trojans* – Atlas Genius
2. *Energy* – Fireboy DML
3. *Atlantis* – Seafret
4. *Mona Lisa* – Remii
5. *Dreaming* – Smallpools
6. *Postcards* – James Blunt
7. *Die for You* – Justin Bieber

He put it on shuffle rotation.

The first track began to play through the phone speaker, soft and tinny in the quiet suite. *Trojans* by Atlas Genius.

...Your Trojan's in my head...

The lyrics hit him with a wry irony. That was exactly what she was doing. She was a horse inside his walls, dismantling his defenses from the inside out while he slept.

He placed the phone on the leather armchair and moved to the bed.

He lay down next to her, on top of the covers at first, then sliding beneath them as the cool air of the cabin bit at his skin. He lay on his back, staring at the ceiling, trying to maintain a respectful distance, but the moment his weight settled into the mattress, Juliet shifted.

Instinctively, without waking, she rolled toward the heat.
She draped an arm over his chest.
She buried her face in his shoulder.

Terdoo froze for a second, then exhaled, his body relaxing into the contact. He closed his eyes, feeling the rise and fall of her breath against his neck, and a singular, mundane thought drifted through his mind as the music played on.

Qantas really does have the very best beds in all of aviation.

And then, he slept.

Chapter 7

New York City

19th November, 2019. **Time:** 9:00 PM

November in New York was a picture of premature darkness, but inside the penthouse, the world was insulated by wealth and the invincible arrogance of youth. It was 2019, and the cultural aftershocks of *Black Panther* were still vibrating through. Terdoo, barely twenty years old, wore the influence on his face; his hair was cut into a sharp, low afro, accompanied by a goatee and a visible mustache that gave him a look of regal defiance. He was leaner then, less guarded, possessing an outgoing personality that hadn't yet been tempered by tragedy. He stood in front of the floor-to-ceiling mirror, adjusting a custom Chrome Hearts suit, the gothic silver detailing gleaming under the chandelier lights. Over his head, he draped a specialized anti-paparazzi scarf, a piece of fabric woven with reflective threads designed to turn him into a ghost in photographs.

He was at the summit. He had just swept the awards ceremony the night before, solidifying his place as one of the best in the world at his craft. But the man staring back at him in the mirror wasn't looking at the accolades; he was looking for the ring in his back pocket.

Rosaline Dostoev walked into the room, and the air seemed to leave it.

She was a Russian supermodel from a lineage of wealth, a twenty-year-old phenomenon who had been walking runways since she was fifteen. She was wearing a white dress that seemed poured over her frame, ethereal and pure, a stark contrast to the dark, chaotic history that bound them. Their love was not a fairy tale; it was a war that had turned into a treaty. In high school, they had hated each other with the specific, venomous intensity that only exists between two privileged children used to getting their way. Their fights had been legendary, spilling out of classrooms and into the hallways.

Terdoo remembered the day the war ended. He had been young, wild, and cruel, and during a heated argument, he had made a cutting, careless remark about her mother's absence, unaware that the woman was battling stage-four cancer. Later that night, at a party where the liquor flowed too freely, Rosaline had cornered him. She didn't scream. She just told him, with a terrifying calmness, exactly how hollow of a human being he was. Struck by guilt and a sudden, sobering clarity, he had volunteered to drive her home. That silent car ride had changed the trajectory of their lives, transforming enemies into soulmates.

"You cancelled the pool party," Rosaline said now, her voice soft but laced with disappointment. She stood behind him, looking at his reflection.

"I couldn't handle the sun, Rose," Terdoo admitted, turning to face her. "The boys and I... we celebrated hard last night. I needed the morning to recover."

Rosaline's face tightened. She was down-to-earth, funny, and fiercely intelligent, but she had a line she wouldn't cross. She had quit alcohol entirely, trying to lead by example.

"You're still hungover," she noted, stepping closer and smelling the stale remnants of whiskey on his skin. "I hate it when you drink like that, King. It makes you slow. It makes you someone else."

"It's just for the celebration," he promised, reaching for her waist. "Tonight is different. Just dinner. No cameras. Just us."

"Too much alcohol was the situation that got us together," she whispered, resting her forehead against his chest. "I don't want to risk it being a double-edged sword. Promise me you'll stop."

"I promise," he lied, kissing the top of her head. He didn't mean to lie, but he didn't think he needed to stop. Not tonight. Tonight, he was going to propose.

They left the penthouse and descended into the neon-lit belly of the city. The paparazzi were waiting outside the restaurant, a pack of wolves sensing prey, but Terdoo's scarf did its job. As the flashes popped, blinding and rapid, his face became a void of white light in their lenses, leaving only Rosaline to shine. She smiled for them, a professional mask of grace, but her hand gripped his tightly as they pushed through the doors.

The restaurant was crowded, alive with music and laughter. They sat at a corner booth, the city skyline glittering through the window behind them. Terdoo ordered a drink to settle his nerves—the excitement of the proposal was vibrating in his fingertips, making him jittery. He saw the disappointment in Rosaline's eyes when the glass touched the table, but he ignored it, telling himself it was the last one.

Then, the music stopped. Not because someone hit pause, but because the sound of an automatic weapon tore through the atmosphere.

Six shots rang out in rapid succession. Screams erupted. Chaos took the room.

Terdoo heard the shots. His brain registered the danger. He was trained in self-defense; he spent hours in the gym honing his reflexes. But he had been drinking. The alcohol, combined with the adrenaline of the looming proposal, created a fog, a split-second delay between perception and action. He saw the gunman near the entrance. He moved to stand, to pull Rosaline down, but his limbs felt heavy, underwater.

Rosaline didn't hesitate. She didn't have the training, but she had the instinct.

She saw the barrel swing toward their table. She saw Terdoo struggling to rise. And in that fraction of a second, she made a choice. She threw herself across the table, placing her body between him and the bullet.

The impact was sickeningly loud.

She was thrown back against him, the force knocking the wind out of her. Terdoo caught her, sliding down to the floor as the room dissolved into pandemonium. He looked down, and his world ended. The beautiful white dress, the symbol of her purity and their future, was soaking red, the blood blooming rapidly from a wound directly over her heart.

"Rose! No, no, no!" Terdoo screamed, pressing his hands against the wound, trying to keep the life inside her.

She looked up at him, her breathing ragged, blood bubbling past her lips. She was fading fast, the light in her eyes dimming like a dying star.

"King," she gasped.

Desperation clawed at his throat. He couldn't save her. He knew he couldn't save her. So he tried to give her the only thing he had left. With bloody, trembling hands, he reached into his pocket and pulled out the ring box. He fumbled it open, revealing the diamond he had chosen with such hope only days ago.

"Marry me," he sobbed, tears streaming down his face, mixing with the blood on her skin. "Please, Rose. Marry me. Stay with me."

Rosaline looked at the ring. Then she looked at him.

She smiled, a weak, heartbreaking expression of absolute love and terrible sadness. She summoned the last of her strength and closed her hand over his, curling his fingers back around the ring box. She pushed it away.

"No," she whispered, refusing to bind him to a ghost. "I love you, King."

She exhaled.

And then, she was gone. Her eyes remained open, staring up at him, but the intelligence, the humor, the fire—it all vanished, leaving behind only glass. He stared into those lifeless eyes, the ring still clutched in his bloody hand, realizing that his hesitation, his drink, his arrogance, had cost him the only thing that mattered.

Sydney Time: 5:00 AM, Day 2

London Time: 6:00 PM, Day 1

Location: *Near Aleutian Islands, Alaska*

Terdoo woke up with a jolt.

The nightmare had been a recurring visitor for seven years, a script he knew by heart, but tonight, mercifully, it hadn't come. Instead, he was pulled from sleep by the sharp vibration of his phone alarm. He silenced it immediately, his hand shaking slightly as the adrenaline of waking faded into the quiet hum of the cabin.

He sat on the edge of the leather chair, his heart rate slowly returning to normal. He looked over at the bed.

Juliet was still sleeping, curled up in the duvet like a baby, safe, breathing, alive.

He stared at her for a long time, the image of those lifeless eyes from 2019 superimposing themselves over her peaceful face for a terrifying second. He stood up abruptly, needing to move, needing to wash the memory off his skin.

He walked out of the suite, moving silently through the cabin to the front lavatory. He locked the door and gripped the edges of the sink, staring at his reflection in the mirror. He turned the tap on, letting the cold water run, and splashed his face, rinsing his mouth, scrubbing his hands as if the blood was still there. It was all he could do. To shower on a long-haul flight would be madness, but he needed to feel clean. He needed to remember that he was here, in the sky, and not on the floor of a New York restaurant.

Chapter 8

Suite 1A, *Near Aleutian Islands, Alaska*

Date: 13th February, 2027

Time: 5:00 AM (Sydney) / 6:00 PM (London - Day 1)

The synth-pop bassline of Twenty One Pilots' *Formidable* pulsed through the suite, a heartbeat synthesized in a studio that seemed to synchronize with the vibration of the aircraft floor, and Juliet woke not to the sound of an alarm, but to the sensation of being watched. She opened her eyes to the dim amber lighting of the cabin, the air recycled and cool against her cheek, and found Terdoo sitting in the leather armchair, his face illuminated by the harsh blue glow of his phone screen as he scrolled through emails with the grim determination of a man dismantling a bomb. *He looks like a statue carved from worry.* She lay there for a moment, the Martin Grant duvet pulled up to her chin, studying the sharp angle of his jaw and the way his brow furrowed, a landscape of tension that she had somehow navigated in her sleep.

He turned.

His eyes caught hers.

The scrolling stopped.

"You look very serious for a man wearing pajamas," she murmured, her voice rough with sleep, a sound like gravel moving under water.

Terdoo didn't smile immediately, but the tension around his eyes softened, the "Cold Void" retreating just enough to let the warmth of the room in. He locked his phone and placed it face down on the table, the music filling the silence between them with lyrics about loyalty and fear.

"The world doesn't stop just because we are in the sky," he said, though his voice lacked its usual bite.

Juliet sat up, the movement rustling the sheets, and a heavy, textured silence settled over the room. They had crossed a meridian that wasn't on any map. Sharing a bed, breathing the same recycled air for hours, entangling limbs in the unconscious honesty of sleep—it was a level of intimacy that she hadn't even granted Ferdinand, the man who had bought a ring. *I have let a stranger past the gate.* The thought made her stomach tighten, a physical contraction of guilt and wonder, because she knew, with a terrifying certainty, that she felt safer in this metal tube with him than she did in her own apartment.

Terdoo stood up, the movement decisive.

"Caffeine," he stated, not asking.

"Cappuccino," she requested, rubbing her eyes. "Heavy on the foam."

"Macchiato," he muttered. "Stained. Just enough milk to hide the bitterness."

He stepped out of the suite, sliding the door partially shut behind him to preserve the warmth of the room. The self-serve pantry was a short walk down the aisle, a designated alcove bathed in soft, clinical light. Terdoo pressed the buttons on the machine, the mechanical hiss of steam loud in the quiet cabin, masking the sound of his own thoughts which were racing in circles. *I am doing the wrong thing*. He was a man of honor, a man who respected boundaries, yet he was standing in a galley making coffee for an engaged woman who had just slept in his bed.

He returned moments later, balancing the two cups. He handed her the cappuccino, their fingers brushing against the porcelain warmth, and for a second, the static electricity in the air spiked, sharp enough to taste.

"Ben and Bea recommended the wellness zone," Terdoo said, retreating to his chair and taking a sip of the dark liquid. "There is a session starting. They are stretching. I intend to join them."

"I'm interested," Juliet said, blowing on the foam. "My back feels like it's been folded into a suitcase."

"Then finish your drink," he said. "We are on a schedule."

They changed quickly—not into street clothes, but into the sleek, charcoal activewear provided in the first-class amenities kit—and walked toward the designated wellness area located between the cabins.

The atmosphere shifted as they passed through the curtain.
The music changed.
The pulse quickened.

Florence + The Machine's *Heartlines* was playing over the speakers, the driving drums and ethereal vocals creating a sense of kinetic urgency, and the space was bathed in a brighter, whiter light that simulated the morning sun. **Ben** and **Bea** were already there, looking disheveled but bright-eyed, standing on yoga mats.

"Look who finally woke up!" Ben called out, grinning. "We thought you two had parachuted out. You're just in time—we've been conscripted."

He pointed to the front of the room. Standing there, dressed not in a crew uniform but in flashy, high-end designer compression gear, was a short, wiry man with calves like tree trunks

and a smile that took up half his face. He was clearly a fellow passenger, but he had taken over the space with the natural authority of a man who owned gyms on three continents.

"Buongiorno!" the man shouted, clapping his hands as Terdoo and Juliet entered. "I am Lorenzo Gratiano. But you must call me **Puck**. Like the fairy, yes? Because I am going to make you fly."

Juliet laughed, the sound bubbling up from her chest, and Terdoo felt a corner of his mouth lift. He recognized the name now—Puck was a celebrity wellness guru, the kind of man who charged a fortune to yell at movie stars in Milan. It seemed he couldn't help himself, even at thirty-five thousand feet.

"Come, come!" Puck commanded, waving them in. "The air is thin, so the blood must pump harder! I am volunteering my services because sitting is death!"

Puck was a whirlwind of energy, moving them through a series of stretches that started simple—neck rolls, touching toes—while Smallpools' *Dreaming* began to play, the upbeat tempo forcing their movements to become sharper, faster.

"Now, we partner!" Puck commanded, clapping again. "Resistance training. Find a body. Make it work."

Ben grabbed Bea.

Terdoo looked at Juliet.

He stepped forward.

"Back to back," Puck instructed. "Link arms. Squat and lift. Trust the other person to hold you up. If you fall, you fall together."

They stood back to back. Terdoo felt the heat of her spine pressing against his, a solid line of warmth that seared through the thin fabric of his shirt. They linked arms, her elbows hooking into his, and as they lowered into the squat, he had to lean his full weight against her, surrendering his balance to the woman who was currently dismantling his life.

"Push," Puck shouted. "Feel the burn! It is the weakness leaving the body!"

They moved in sync, breathing together, the rhythm of the song—*I've got a feeling, I've got a feeling*—matching the thudding of their hearts. Then Puck switched it up. "Face to face! Palm to palm! Push against each other, create the tension!"

They turned.

They raised their hands.

Palms met.

Juliet looked up at him, her eyes wide and dark, her breath coming in short, shallow bursts from the exertion. Terdoo pressed his hands against hers, feeling the delicate strength in her wrists, and for a moment, the rest of the room vanished. Ben, Bea, Puck—they dissolved into the background noise. There was only the pressure of her skin against his, the smell of her vanilla perfume mixing with the sweat of exertion, and the terrified realization that he wanted to pull her into him and never let go.

The air between them thickened.
It felt like gravity was collapsing.
He was going to kiss her.

No.

The word was a hammer in his mind. Terdoo pulled his hands away abruptly, the loss of contact leaving a physical coldness on his palms.

"That's enough," he said, his voice rough.

He turned and walked away, grabbing his towel, leaving the session before the song could finish. Juliet stood there for a second, the shock of his withdrawal hitting her like a slap, before she grabbed her own towel and followed him.

"Intense," Ben whispered to Bea, watching them go.

"Magnetic," Bea corrected. "They don't even see the rest of us."

Juliet caught up to him at the door of Suite 1A. He was standing there, his chest rising and falling, his hand gripping the frame of the door as if to steady the plane itself.

"Terdoo," she started, reaching out.

"Get your stuff," he said, cutting her off.

Juliet froze. The blood drained from her face, leaving her cold. She looked at him, her brown eyes filling with a sudden, stinging hurt. *He is pushing me away again. The walls are back up.*

"You... you want me to leave?" she asked, her voice small.

Terdoo looked at her, and the hardness in his face fractured. He saw the hurt, and he realized his mistake. He stepped closer, invading her personal space, and the "Cold Void" was replaced by a sudden, overwhelming gentleness.

"No," he said softly. "I want you to pack your bag. I want you to go to your suite, brush your teeth, and wash your face."

"Why?" she breathed.

"Because the sun is about to rise," Terdoo explained, his voice low and intimate. "And the best view is on the right side of the aircraft. In Suite 1K. I want to have breakfast with you while the world wakes up."

The relief that washed over her was palpable, a physical loosening of the tension in her shoulders. He wasn't banishing her; he was inviting her.

Terdoo reached out.
He tucked a loose strand of red hair behind her ear.
His fingers lingered on her jaw.

"Go," he whispered, and then he smiled—a devastating, genuine expression that reached his eyes and made her knees feel like water. "I will see you in ten minutes."

"Bye," she managed to squeak out, clutching her towel.

"Bye," he replied, the single word carrying the weight of a promise.

He opened the door to Suite 1A, pointing her across the aisle toward her own room, and leaned against the frame, watching her walk away with a look on his face that suggested he knew exactly how much trouble he was in.

Chapter 9

Approaching the Bering strait

Date: 13th February, 2027

Time: 6:00 AM (Sydney) / 7:00 PM (London - Day 1)

The air in Suite 1K was crisp, recycled, and smelled faintly of the expensive leather binding of the breakfast menu, and **Terdoo** sat in the reclining armchair, freshly showered and dressed in the same vintage loose-fit pants and white shirt he had boarded in, though the fabric now felt heavier, as if it had absorbed the gravity of the last twelve hours. Across from him, **Juliet** was a riot of color against the neutral cabin walls, having changed back into her chaotic Julia Heur dress, her red hair flowing loose and damp from her own attempt at cleaning up in the compact lavatory. The table between them was set with white linen, waiting for the ritual of the morning meal, while the speakers hummed with the laid-back, Afro-fusion rhythm of Joshua Baraka's *Wrong Places*, a song that asked questions about belonging that neither of them wanted to answer out loud.

"So," Juliet started, leaning her chin on her hand, her eyes dancing with a mischief that the early hour hadn't dampened. "The mysterious stranger returns to the scene of the crime."

"The crime?" Terdoo asked, arching an eyebrow as he scanned the menu.

"The ticket," she clarified, grinning. "When you walked into that lounge... honestly, I thought you were a ghost. Or a hitman. You had this energy, like you were cutting through the air instead of walking through it."

Terdoo chuckled, a low sound that vibrated in his chest. "A hitman? I was just trying to get a massage."

"No, seriously," she pressed, her voice dropping to a conspiratorial whisper. "You slammed that boarding pass down like it was a weapon. And then you just... vanished. It was terrifying. And incredibly hot."

Terdoo felt a sudden heat rise up his neck, a physical flush of embarrassment that he hadn't felt since he was a teenager. He laughed, shaking his head, trying to hide behind the leather menu. *She sees too much*. The compliment landed in the center of his chest, heavy and warm, and he found himself glancing over the top of the menu, trying to catch glimpses of her between the pages.

"I aim to please," he deflected, his voice lighter than usual. "Terrifying and hot. I'll put that on my business card."

"You should," she laughed. "It works."

They ordered then, the flight attendant taking their requests with the practiced efficiency of someone who had seen everything. Terdoo chose the French breakfast—delicate madeleines, warm and buttery, paired with freshly squeezed orange juice that caught the light like liquid gold. Juliet, true to form, scanned the "Project Sunrise" specials and pointed decisively to the Shakshuka with spicy chorizo and labneh, a dish that promised heat and complexity.

Terdoo nodded, impressed.
"Bold choice for 35,000 feet," he noted.
"I like a little fire," she replied, holding his gaze.

The food arrived, the smell of spiced tomatoes and baked goods filling the small suite, and they ate in a companionable silence that felt worn-in, comfortable, like a favorite sweater. Terdoo watched her eat, the way she attacked the meal with the same uninhibited joy she applied to everything else, and he felt the "Cold Void" retreat further, pushed back by the sheer force of her presence. *We are not strangers anymore*. The realization was a weight and a relief, settling in his bones.

Outside the window, the world was waking up.

The horizon, which had been a bruised purple for the last hour, suddenly cracked open. A thin line of molten gold spilled across the cloud tops, illuminating the endless expanse of the Arabian Sea below. The light flooded the cabin, turning the walnut wood of the suite into amber and setting Juliet's red hair on fire.

She stopped eating.
She turned to the window.
She gasped softly.

"It's beautiful," she whispered, her reflection ghosting against the glass, superimposed over the rising sun.

Terdoo stopped eating too. He didn't look at the window; he looked at her. He watched the way the light caught the curve of her cheek, the way her eyelashes fluttered as she blinked against the brightness, and he felt a sudden, sharp clarity that cut through the confusion of the night.

"You know," he said, his voice casual, trying to keep the weight of the words from crushing the moment. "After seeing this... seeing the sun rise from this high up, with your hair flowing next to me..."

He paused, taking a sip of his juice, masking the intensity of the thought.

"I think I'll always think of you whenever I look at the sun," he finished simply. "The color matches."

Juliet turned from the window.

She looked at him.

The air went still.

She didn't speak immediately. She just stared at him, her brown eyes wide, processing the casual devastation of the compliment. It wasn't poetry; it was a fact he had just stated, as indisputable as the altitude. *He sees me*. The thought was a physical sensation, a tightening in her throat that made it hard to swallow. It was one of the most beautiful things anyone had ever said to her, and he had said it over orange juice and madeleines.

"That's..." she started, her voice trembling slightly. "That's a dangerous thing to say to a girl, Terdoo."

"Perhaps," he smiled, a small, guarded expression. "But it is true."

They sat there as the sun continued its ascent, climbing higher into the sky, burning away the last of the night's shadows. The music played on—*I've been looking for love in the wrong places*—and for a moment, as the cabin filled with light, they both understood that maybe, for the first time in a long time, they were exactly where they were supposed to be.

Chapter 10

Over the Bering strait

Date: 13th February, 2027

Time: 7:00 AM (Sydney) / 8:00 PM (London - Day 1)

The porcelain clinked softly as **Diane** cleared the remnants of the French breakfast and the Shakshuka, the sound sharp and domestic in the quiet cabin, and the upbeat, stuttering rhythm of Dominic Fike's *Phone Numbers* pulsed from the hidden speakers, but **Terdoo** did not look at the hostess or the empty plates. The bass of the track was a low vibration that seemed to tickle the soles of Juliet's feet, and the contrast between the sunny, irreverent melody and the heavy silence of the cabin made the air feel thick with things unsaid. He reached for his leather-bound journal, the spine cracking with the familiarity of use, and uncapped his fountain pen. He didn't look down at the paper. Instead, he fixed his gaze on **Juliet**, locking onto her brown eyes across the small table, and let his hand move across the page by instinct, the nib scratching a rhythm that matched the sudden, erratic thudding of his heart.

He wrote without blinking, capturing the truth of the last hour in ink:

[
*The eastern sky has nothing on this dawn,
Two suns have risen now that night is gone,
One climbs the clouds, the other sits right here,
And binds a ghost who cannot come too near.*

*A wildfire trapped in strands of copper wire,
A beautifully uninvited fire,
It burns the map I drew to keep me safe,
And turns the cold to something so unsafe.*
]

He stopped at the second stanza, the pen hovering over the paper, sensing that to write more would be to admit too much too soon. Diane stepped out, the electronic latch of the suite clicking shut, sealing them into their private world, and Juliet leaned forward immediately, her curiosity a physical force.

"What are you writing?" she asked, reaching for the book. "A review of the Shakshuka? Or a hit list?"

Terdoo snapped the journal closed, pulling it out of her reach with a speed that blurred in the air.

"It is unfinished," he said, his voice low.

"I want to see," she insisted, scrambling up from her seat, trying to grab the book from his raised hand, her body pressing against his in the narrow space between the table and the chair.

Terdoo looked at her, at the chaotic energy radiating from her, and he simply stood up. He caught her by the waist, his hand encompassing the fabric of the Julia Heur dress, and lifted her. It was effortless, a suspension of gravity, and he moved her weightlessly through the air before setting her down gently on the edge of the unmade bed.

"You might see it in London," he said, placing the journal on the high shelf she couldn't reach. "If we meet when we are done with our respective wars."

"That's not fair," Juliet pouted, though a smile tugged at her lips. "I want to see it now. I'll make you a deal. Give it to me before we land if I can prove that the remaining hours won't be boring."

Terdoo leaned against the wall, crossing his arms, looking at the woman who had turned his colorless life into a Pollock painting.

"I used to like things calm," he admitted, the confession surprising him. "I built a life on silence. But after spending just hours with you... I seem to have developed a taste for excitement. You are a bad influence, Juliet."

"The best kind," she giggled, the sound light and effervescent.

"Is it okay if I share your suite till we land?" he asked suddenly, the shift in topic catching her off guard. "I like the absolute seclusion of the middle suite, so I kept that for work, but I'm afraid I no longer own Suite 1A."

Juliet blinked, confusion clouding her face. "You don't own it? You bought the whole row. Did you get evicted from your own plane?"

"Not evicted," Terdoo smiled. "I gave it away. To Ben and Bea. It is their anniversary trip, and Economy is no place to celebrate defying a Duke."

The realization hit her, and the smile that broke across Juliet's face was brighter than the sun climbing outside the window. He had given up his sanctuary, his £100,000 seat, so the runaway lovers could sleep in comfort. *He is a good man hiding inside a hard shell.*

"You are welcome to stay," she said, her voice softening. "Sharing a suite with someone as understanding as you... it is all I could have wished for. But you will have to obey my rules going forward."

She grinned, a mischievous, troublesome glint returning to her eyes.

"Agreed," Terdoo nodded, accepting his fate.

"Rule number one," she announced, patting the space beside her. "We are watching a movie. And you are not allowed to complain."

"What are we watching?"

"*Roman Holiday*," he suggested, scrolling through the entertainment system on the wall monitor. "Gregory Peck. Audrey Hepburn. A classic."

Terdoo reached for the side console, tapping the screen to silence the music, and the sudden absence of Dominic Fike's voice left a ringing in the ears that felt like a pressure drop in the cabin.

"I have never watched a movie made before 2005," Juliet stated flatly.

Terdoo froze, the remote hovering in mid-air. He looked at her with genuine horror. "That is... a cultural crime. We are fixing that immediately."

"Fine," she relented. "But we are doing it my way. Fast forward through the slow parts. We finish it in an hour."

They settled onto the bed, propped up against the pillows, the suite darkened against the glare of the sun. The black and white images flickered on the screen, painting their faces in shades of grey, and as they sped through the streets of 1950s Rome at an occasional 2x speed, they talked over the dialogue, dissecting the world.

"Which city is your favorite?" Juliet asked as Audrey Hepburn got a haircut. "I bet you like Geneva. Or Kyoto. Somewhere silent and organized."

"Lagos," Terdoo said instantly.

"Lagos?" She looked at him, shocked. "Nigeria? It's... chaotic. It's loud. It never sleeps."

"Exactly," he replied, watching the screen. "And New York. And Tokyo. I love the noise. When the world outside is screaming, the silence inside my head feels earned. It drowns out the ghosts. In a quiet city, my thoughts are too loud."

"That's backwards," she mused. "I love the quiet ones. I spend my life on stages with thousands of people screaming my name. Give me a cabin in the woods in Vermont any day."

"Then perhaps," Terdoo said, glancing at her as the movie reached its bittersweet end on the screen, "we are just looking for what we don't have."

On the screen, the Princess walked away from the reporter, a duty chosen over love, and in the suite, the sensory detail of the moment felt fated—the smell of her vanilla perfume, the hum of the engine, and the black-and-white tragedy mirroring the choice they would soon have to make when the wheels touched the ground in London.

Chapter 11

Chukchi Sea (Arctic Ocean)

Date: 13th February, 2027

Time: 8:00 AM (Sydney) / 9:00 PM (London - Day 1)

The credits of *Roman Holiday* dissolved into a hollow black screen, and the low, driving pulse of Linkin Park's *Over Each Other* began to vibrate through the suite, the bass a heavy thrum that seemed to anchor the aircraft to the very air it cut through, but Juliet did not move to turn the lights up. She remained propped against the silk pillows, her red hair a tangled map of the last hour, and the way the light from the monitor caught the moisture in her eyes made them look like polished stones at the bottom of a clear stream.

The sunlight through the window formed a perfect cross.

As the aircraft leveled off, the beam of light hit the silver edge of the coffee spoon and refracted against the walnut partition in a shape so precise it looked drawn by a compass. It sat there, unmoving despite the slight pitch of the plane, a golden intersection that seemed to mark the exact center of the world. The dust motes in the air seemed to orbit the light like tiny, silent planets, creating a miniature galaxy within the pressurized confines of the suite.

"I didn't just like it," Juliet whispered, her voice a fragile vibration that barely rose above the rhythmic guitar of the track. "I love LOVED it."

Terdoo felt a sudden, sharp warmth bloom in the center of his chest, a sensation like a radiator kicking on in a long-vacant house, and he watched the way her expression remained soft even as the tragedy of the movie's ending hung between them. He thought of the ring sitting on her finger, of the man named Ferdinand who held the title he was currently trespassing upon, and the thought felt like a jagged piece of glass shifting in his throat. *She belongs to a world I am not invited to, and I am merely a passenger in her heart for the next few hours.*

"I spent a week in Marrakesh when the heat was a physical wall," Terdoo began, his voice low and steady, "and the air smelled so thick of cumin and roasted lamb that you could almost chew it, but the red city never felt as vibrant as this cabin does right now." He leaned back, his eyes distant as he described the way the morning light in Kyoto hit the golden leaf of the Kinkaku-ji temple, a sight so still and silent that he had forgotten to breathe for a full minute.

"I've seen the Grand Canyon at sunrise," Juliet said, her voice laced with a heavy, textured longing, "and I've watched the fog roll over the Golden Gate Bridge, but the borders of the states are the only walls I've ever known." She watched him, her pulse jumping in the hollow of her neck, and the way he spoke of the world made her feel as though she were standing on the edge of a great, terrifying cliff. *This is not a meeting; it is a collision of two planets that were never meant to share an orbit.*

Terdoo shifted his weight, and the leather of the chair creaked in sympathy as he told her about the International Balloon Festival in Château-d'Oex, Switzerland. He described the silence of the Alpine morning, a cold so sharp it felt like needles in the lungs, and the way the silk giants rose from the snow like a thousand multicolored lanterns. "When the burners roar, you feel the heat on your face, but then it stops, and you are just... drifting," he said, his hand moving in a slow arc through the air. "The world below looks like a toy set, and for a moment, you realize that none of the things that worry you on the ground actually matter."

Juliet leaned forward, her chin resting on her hand, and the smell of her vanilla perfume seemed to intensify in the quiet space between them. "I've spent my life in cities made of glass and steel, where the only silence is the kind you find in a recording booth," she mused, and she asked him about the rain in Paris.

He told her of a night in the Latin Quarter where the cobblestones looked like black pearls under the streetlamps, and how the smell of wet stone and old books was so intoxicating it felt like a drug. He spoke of Iceland, where the wind screamed across the volcanic plains like a wounded animal, and how he had stood in the middle of a frozen field to watch the green fire of the Aurora borealis dance across the sky. "It doesn't look like light," he explained, his eyes locking onto hers. "It looks like the sky is thinking out loud."

They talked for what felt like an eternity, the conversation flowing from the salt-spray of the Amalfi Coast to the neon-soaked chaos of Tokyo, where the lights were so bright they drowned out the stars. Terdoo spoke of a party in Brazil, a night where the humidity had felt like a second skin and the percussion of the samba drums had vibrated in his very marrow, and he mentioned a Swedish model he had met there. He described her as a woman of iron and grace who had become one of his closest friends, a person who understood the weight of being watched by the world.

The air in the suite grew suddenly, sharply cold.
Juliet's jaw tightened.
She looked at her hands.

The image of the Swedish woman was a sudden, unwelcome shadow in the room, a physical prickle of heat rising to her cheeks that had nothing to do with the cabin's climate control. Beneath the sudden tightening of her throat, however, she felt a loosening of the tension behind her ribs because she realized he had let someone in. He was a man who occasionally allowed himself the luxury of a human connection, a man who didn't just exist in the "Cold Void" he so often inhabited.

Terdoo saw the shift in her expression, the way her eyes clouded over for a fraction of a second, and he quickly moved the conversation back to the safety of the screen. "If you loved the Princess in Rome, then you are in trouble," he noted, his voice lighter, the excitement a physical electricity in his fingertips. "To have lived this long without seeing the classics is a tragedy I

cannot allow to continue. You must watch the *Lord of the Rings* trilogy when we land. And *Star Wars*. They are the only things that keep the modern world from feeling entirely hollow."

"Look at you," Juliet said, a soft laugh bubbling up from her chest as she pointed to the way he was leaning forward, the stoic mask having slipped to reveal a spark in his eyes that was almost childlike in its intensity. "I have used up exactly one hour of your time, and you are still clearly excited. I think the 'bad influence' is winning, Mr. Yimam."

This is surreal, she thought, her eyes tracing the line of his jaw in the dim amber light. *I am forty thousand feet in the air with a man who was a stranger twelve hours ago, and I feel more seen than I ever have on a stage.*

"I think I've had enough of movies for now," she suggested, her gaze dropping to the crystal glasses on the tray, her voice dropping to a low, intimate register. "I think we should do a wine tasting. We are in the air and we are safe, and I want to see if your palate is as sophisticated as your library."

Chapter 12

Approaching North Pole

Date: 13th February, 2027

Time: 9:00 AM (Sydney) / 10:00 PM (London - Day 1)

The driving, soulful grit of Tom Walker's *Head Underwater* filled the suite, the lyrics of struggle and oxygen-depletion bouncing off the leather walls, and the sunlight had shifted into a deeper, more aggressive gold that seemed to search out the hidden lines in their faces. Juliet sat on the edge of the bed, her fingers tracing the rim of an empty crystal glass, and she watched the way Terdoo's expression remained a locked fortress even as the music invited the walls to crumble.

The wine in the decanter pulsed with the music.

As the bass notes hit the floorboards, the surface of the dark liquid did not ripple in circles but vibrated into a perfect, six-pointed star that held its shape for the duration of the chorus, a geometric impossibility that ignored the aircraft's tilt. It was a shared hallucination of physics, a sign that the cabin had become a space where the rules of the earth were merely suggestions.

"The double sunrise is a reset," Juliet said, her voice cutting through the heavy percussion, "and we are on the longest flight in the history of the world, which means we are in a vacuum between the people we were and the people we are going to be." She reached for the bottle of vintage Bordeaux that Diane had left on the side console, and she looked at him with a challenge that made the air in the suite feel thin and electric.

Terdoo looked at the glass, and then at her, and the ghost of his sobriety—the accident, the blood on his hands, the discipline of seven years—shifted like a shadow in the corner of his mind. "I have built my life on the clarity of the void, and I have found that the only way to keep the ghosts silent is to stay sharp," he argued, his voice a low vibration that matched the hum of the engine.

"But you are not resetting," she countered, leaning in until the scent of vanilla was the only thing he could breathe. "You are just holding your breath. Let the wine be the first step toward the surface. You said last night that you struggle to see the literal hand of God, but maybe the reset is the miracle you aren't looking for."

He watched her for a long, textured heartbeat, and the resistance in his chest finally fractured like ice under a sudden sun. He nodded once, and as the first drop of the dark liquid hit his tongue, the "Cold Void" didn't just retreat; it seemed to dissolve into a warmth that radiated through his bones.

"I was raised on the promise of a literal God," Terdoo said after the second glass, his gaze fixed on the way the light caught the deep red of the wine. "My parents are clergy, and they taught me that every breath is a gift and every tragedy is a lesson, and for a long time, I believed them." He paused, his knuckles turning white as he gripped the stem of the glass. "I had experienced encounters that proved He was real—moments where I overcame things I shouldn't have, where the path opened when it should have been blocked—but then I lost the one person who made the blessing feel like more than just a lucky streak. Losing her felt like a mockery, a divine negligence that I couldn't reconcile with the love I was taught to honor."

"Who was she?" Juliet asked, her voice a fragile thread.

"Rosaline Dostoev," he said, and the name seemed to drain the air from the room. "We were in New York, and it was the night I was going to ask her to marry me, and the world was supposed to be at our feet." He described the sound of the automatic weapon tearing through the music of the restaurant, and the way the white of her dress had been erased by a blooming, violent red. "She threw herself across the table to save a man who was too slow to stand, and she bled out in my arms while I fumbled for a ring that no longer had a finger to call home. I watched the light leave her eyes, and in that second, I decided that if God could allow a heart like hers to stop, I no longer wanted to hear His voice."

Juliet's glass nearly slipped from her hand, her brown eyes widening until they seemed to swallow her face. "Rosaline?" she breathed, the shock a physical weight on her chest. "Terdoo... I was a fan of hers long before I ever had a stage of my own. She wasn't just a supermodel; she was the reason I believed a woman could be both a fortress and a flame."

She reached for her phone, her fingers trembling as she scrolled through a digital archive she had kept for years, and she found a video clip that made Terdoo's heart stop. It was an interview from Rosaline's first month as a certified phenomenon, a moment when the entire world was desperate to know the identity of the "mystery man" she was dating.

Terdoo leaned in, his breath hitching, because he had attended this interview with her but had been on his phone in the wings, never actually hearing the words she had spoken to the camera.

On the screen, Rosaline's face was a map of absolute love.

"He thinks he is the one holding me up," she said, her voice a silver melody that Terdoo hadn't heard in seven years, "but I think I am the one holding him down. He is so talented, so hardworking, and I see him intentionally holding back his own light because he wants to watch me succeed first. He wants to pursue his dreams later, but I know it is just a matter of time. The universe is going to force his greatness to shine for everyone to see, because he is the best man I have ever known."

The video ended, and the silence that followed was a physical ache.
Terdoo's throat tightened.
The air grew heavy.

"She would have been so proud of the man you are now," Juliet said softly, her hand finding his. "She wouldn't want you to punish yourself with this apathy toward the divine, Terdoo. She clearly loved you too much to want you to live in a tomb, and she would want you to see that the universe did exactly what she predicted."

Terdoo didn't speak, but the way he looked at the wine glass suggested he was finally rethinking the silence of the last seven years.

"I have never been in love before," Juliet admitted, her voice dropping to a register of raw honesty that stripped away the outgoing mask she wore for the world. "I am good at talking, and I am good at letting people see the version of me that glows, but no one knows the emotional depths I hide in the dark. Even now, I can imagine never seeing or talking to you again when this plane lands, and it already feels like a part of me would be gone with you."

She looked at the golden light on the wall, her eyes filling with a sudden heat. "I spent my life thinking my father, Chief Judge Gabriel Williams, was a cold man because he didn't love me, but seeing how much you hurt from losing Rosaline... I think I finally understand that he was just a man who had lost his mother, and then my mother, and he was just trying to survive the quiet."

He reached out.
He wiped the tear.
He pulled her closer.

Juliet moved with a sudden, desperate grace, sitting on his legs and wrapping her arms around his neck, and they stayed there in that warm embrace, the engine's roar fading into the background of a world that finally felt small enough to manage. In the golden glow of Suite 1K, they were **beginning to finally heal in their hearts.**

"I need to go," Terdoo whispered after a while, his voice rough but clear. "I need to go pick up my jacket from the other suite." He stood up, helping her back to the edge of the bed, and his eyes held a new kind of clarity. "Have your boots on, Juliet. We are having dinner with a very important guest in Suite 2k."

The excitement on her face was palpable.

Chapter 13

Directly over North Pole

Date: 13th February, 2027

Time: 10:00 AM (Sydney) / 11:00 PM (London - Day 1)

The air in the galley was cooler than the warmth they had left behind in 1K, and Terdoo walked with a renewed, steady gait while Juliet followed, her boots clicking against the carpeted floor with a rhythmic precision that matched the sudden, expectant thudding of her heart. They stopped before the dark wood of the door to Suite 2K, and the lack of a nameplate or any indication of the occupant made the space feel like a vacuum in the middle of the sky.

"The man inside is a friend," Terdoo said, turning to her with a look that was softer than his usual stoic mask, and the way the dim corridor lighting caught the angle of his jaw made him look like a man who was finally stepping out of a long shadow.

"Who is he?" Juliet asked, her voice a low vibration.

"I just call him Oga, or Big Chief," he replied, a genuine laugh bubbling up from his chest, "and I honestly cannot remember the last time I used his actual name."

Juliet felt a smile tug at her lips. *Typical Nigerian*. She had spent enough time in recording studios with Lagos-born artistes to recognize the linguistic shorthand of respect, the use of monikers that carried more weight than any birth name ever could, and the familiarity of the slang made the mystery of the suite feel slightly more grounded.

The door slid open into a pocket of impossible light.

The suite was bathed in a glow that didn't seem to originate from the overhead LEDs but appeared to radiate from the very center of the room. It was a brighter, whiter radiance that cast no shadows against the far wall, a visual anomaly that made the furniture look as though it were floating in a void of pure energy. The air smelled of expensive oud and something crisp, like ozone after a thunderstorm.

As they stepped inside, Juliet's breath hitched in her throat, and the sudden widening of her pupils was the only outward sign of the shock that vibrated through her bones. She recognized HIM immediately—the silhouette, the presence, the gravity that had shifted the landscape of global industries—and for a second, her lungs simply forgot how to function.

Terdoo stepped forward, his face breaking into a wide, bright expression of brotherhood, and he embraced the man with a warmth that Juliet had never seen him extend to anyone else. "Big Chief," Terdoo said, the word carrying a deep, resonant affection.

Juliet extended her hand with a forced, practiced grace, but the mystery host reached out and held it gently with both of his, his palms a dry, grounding heat against her skin. "You must be really special to make Terdoo bring you to lunch with me," HE whispered, leaning in with a conspiratorial wink toward his friend, and the way HE looked at her made her feel as though she were the only person in the sky.

"Sit," HE commanded, gesturing to the bed while HE reclaimed the plush first-class chair.

The laid-back, melodic rhythm of Preston Pablo's *Flowers Need Rain* began to drift from the speakers, and Terdoo tilted his head, a look of surprise crossing his features. "When did our music tastes become so similar?" he asked, glancing at his friend.

Big Chief laughed, a rich, deep sound that filled the small space. "You forget that it was you who curated the playlist I use for relaxation, and I specifically picked this track when you informed me you were coming over for lunch with a lady." HE turned his gaze to Juliet, the intensity of his stare enough to make the static electricity in the room spike. "I have known this man for over four years, and I have never once seen him with a lady or heard him speak of one other than his sisters. I was... curious."

"How do you two know each other?" Juliet asked, her curiosity a physical pressure behind her eyes.

"Terdoo's publishing company needed information from a direct source to write a specific book," HE explained, his hands moving with a fluid authority as he spoke. "When he reached out, I had to respond because I respected his work—I have been a fan of his words for a long time. We found that working together was effortless, and we became unlikely friends despite coming from completely polar fields of greatness."

Juliet watched Terdoo, and the way he sat there, comfortable in the presence of a giant, made her see him in a new light. *He is a genius I have only begun to map.*

The lunch arrived—a heavy, aromatic meal for their host and a selection of light snacks for Terdoo and Juliet—and the conversation expanded to fill the hour, moving through the speculative curves of world politics and the shifting sands of the entertainment industry. They spoke of technological advancements with a kinetic urgency, and as the talk turned toward the future of aviation, the mystery guest leaned forward, his eyes bright with a cold, calculated ambition.

"I am willing to invest billions into the next generation of flight," HE stated clearly, "and I have always been fond of Qantas, even if this is the first time I have been forced to fly commercial in years."

"Qantas has a history that began in 1920," Terdoo added, his voice dropping into the rhythmic, instructional tone of a historian, "and I have an idea for a joint venture that would redefine the luxury of the southern route."

"Your eye for investments has always been perfect," Big Chief agreed, nodding slowly. "We will have dinner in London to discuss the specifics. I owe you that much for the gift of these suites—they gave me the only reason I needed to take a mini-vacation in Australia."

They moved into more mundane territories, the tension of the business talk dissolving into the easy rhythm of shared stories, and Juliet felt the warmth of the wine from the previous hour still humming in her blood. "It's been a long flight," she said, her voice soft and unguarded, "but sharing a suite has made the time move in ways I didn't expect."

The slip of the tongue hung in the air, a tiny, intimate confession. Terdoo's expression didn't change. Big Chief smiled.

The hour drew to a close with a smooth, natural finality, and as Terdoo and Juliet stood to leave, they bid farewell to the man they called Big Chief. The door slid shut behind them, and the quiet of the corridor felt heavy and textured after the energy of the room.

"I need to go to the bar," Terdoo suggested, his hand momentarily brushing against her arm, "and I need to talk to John. Talking to him last night helped me center my thoughts, and I think I need that clarity again."

"I'll go with you," Juliet replied.

They walked toward the lounge, the expectation of John's calm wisdom acting as a magnetic pull on Terdoo's senses, and they pushed through the heavy curtain to find the space bathed in a dim, sterile blue light that felt miles away from the amber warmth of the previous night. The bar was empty, the polished granite counter reflecting the cold glow of the overhead panels, and the only sound was the low, mechanical hum of the self-service espresso machine.

Terdoo signaled for a passing hostess—Diane—and he waited for her to approach, a faint smile touching his lips.

"Is John around?" Terdoo asked, his voice casual. "The man who was working the bar last night? I wanted to thank him for the conversation."

Diane paused, her expression professional and blank. "I'm sorry, sir?" she asked, her head tilting. "There is no John on the crew manifest for this flight."

"He was helping out," Juliet added, a sudden lightness blooming in her chest as she looked at the empty, pristine counter. "Silver hair, quite philosophical? He made us drinks around midnight."

"We don't have anyone by that description on staff, and we certainly don't allow volunteers behind the bar," Diane replied, offering a polite but confused smile. "It's a self-service station during the quiet hours, and I've been the only one assigned to this zone since Sydney."

Terdoo looked at Juliet.
The air grew still.
His pulse quickened.

They turned back to the bar, and they saw that the granite was completely dry, and the space where the man had stood for hours was as untouched as if the plane had just left the hangar. There was no scent of tea, no discarded polishing cloth, and no evidence that anyone had ever been there to offer them the middle path.

A soft, melodic laugh bubbled up from Juliet's chest, a sound of genuine wonder that seemed to harmonize with the low hum of the engines. "He really was a ghost," she whispered, and the realization didn't feel like a weight but like a gift, a surreal glitch in the fabric of the flight that belonged only to them.

Terdoo felt a sudden, buoyant heat behind his ribs, and he shook his head, a smile finally breaking across his face. "In a world of logic and physics, I think we just found the only thing that doesn't have a fracture point," he said, his voice light and unburdened.

They stood in the empty lounge, laughing softly at the beautiful impossibility of it, and for the first time in thirteen hours, the sky felt like a place where anything could happen.

Chapter 14

High Arctic

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 11:00 AM (Sydney) / 12:00 AM (London - Day 2)

The air in the narrow corridor felt thinner, charged with a strange, static energy that made the fine hairs on Juliet's arms stand at attention, and the soft, acoustic swell of Novo Amor's *Anchor* began to drift through the overhead speakers, the hollow reverb of the guitar creating a sense of being submerged in a dream that neither of them wanted to wake from. They walked toward Suite 1A, their steps synchronized in the dim, blue-hued night lighting of the cabin, and the silence of the aircraft was a heavy, textured thing that seemed to vibrate with the impossibility of the last ten minutes.

"I didn't have a single drop of alcohol," Terdoo said, his voice a low, grounded vibration that anchored the surreal moment to the floorboards. "I was stone-cold sober, Juliet, and I saw him as clearly as I see you right now."

Juliet let out a soft, breathy laugh that was less about humor and more about the sheer, electric shock of the shared experience. "We both saw him," she whispered, her eyes wide and dancing with an excitement that made her look younger, less burdened. "He wasn't a shadow or a trick of the light. He was... there." *He was fated. We were supposed to hear those words.*

They stopped at the door of Suite 1A and Terdoo knocked, a sharp, domestic sound that felt out of place in the middle of their supernatural bubble. After a moment, the door slid back to reveal Ben and Bea, their faces flushed with the heavy, comfortable glow of time spent in each other's arms. They were deep into their "London sync" sleep, and the scent of expensive wine and rest drifted into the hall.

"Terdoo? Everything alright, mate?" Ben asked, rubbing his eyes and grinning as he leaned against the frame, his arm draped possessively around a sleepy but smiling Bea.

"Sorry to wake you," Terdoo said, his expression carefully neutral, "but we were just talking about the bar last night. Do either of you remember a man working there? Silver hair, a bit older, very philosophical?"

Ben and Bea looked at each other, a silent, synchronized communication passing between them before they both shook their heads. "Mate, we were absolutely flying on that vintage red," Ben admitted with a chuckle. "I don't think I could have told you if the bartender was a man or a unicorn. We only remember you two because you came over to the booth to talk after you left the bar."

"Yeah," Bea added, her voice soft with sleep. "It was just a self-service station as far as we knew. We didn't see anyone else."

They agreed for the first time.

The certainty in their voices was a final, slamming door on the logic of the physical world. Terdoo and Juliet exchanged a glance, a silent realization sparking between them that made the air feel thick enough to taste, and they left the couple to the quiet of the European night, walking away with their laughter bubbling up softly as they retreated from the realm of the ordinary.

"Let's go to 1F," Terdoo suggested, his hand finding the small of her back to guide her. "There are no windows there. No moonlight, no cabin glow. Just the dark. We can just... be."

They entered the middle suite, and as the door clicked shut, the absolute darkness of the room wrapped around them like a heavy velvet shroud. Outside, the Austrian Alps were buried in a winter midnight, but inside the windowless 1F, the world had ceased to exist. They lay down together on the bed, staring up at the invisible ceiling, and the "Cold Void" that had defined Terdoo's existence for many years felt as though it had been filled with a sudden, radiant light.

"Last night, I told John—or whoever he was—that I didn't have total trust in God," Terdoo mused, his voice a textured thread in the dark. "I found it funny, even arrogant, to think I had the world figured out. But this... the timing, the place, the sheer impossibility of it... it's a catalyst. I'm remembering my roots, Juliet. It's like the universe had to take me thirty-eight thousand feet into the sky just to make me look up."

"I've always felt there was more," Juliet breathed, her hand finding his in the space between them. "When I was thirteen, locked in that van alone and terrified... I felt a physical arm around my shoulders. I felt a weight, a comfort that shouldn't have been there. I think we are fated to see the things others miss." *I think I was fated to find the man who sees the sun in my hair.*

The shuffle on Terdoo's playlist shifted, and the melancholic, soaring piano of Dean Lewis's *How Do I Say Goodbye* began to fill the dark suite. The lyrics about loss and the inevitable end of a journey hit the space between them like a physical blow, and the air grew heavy with the realization that the flight was moving toward its final chapters.

"What changes about our lives when we land?" Terdoo asked, the question a jagged edge in the silence.

"I plan on being the daughter my father deserves," Juliet said, her voice a map of a new, certain future. "He is putting in so much effort to be in my life now, and I want to spend the rest of my time being close to him. I want to rest in the warmth he's finally offering." She smiled in the dark, a secret, happy expression. "He actually bought a ticket to every single one of my shows last year. He attended them all as a fan in the first class, just to show me he was there. It took me a long time to realize that was his way of saying he loved me."

Terdoo felt a sharp, sudden heat behind his ribs. "I want to do something crazy," he admitted. "I want to let the public know that I am more than a rich man that attends board meetings and contract signings. I've hidden from the world to avoid the scrutiny, but I think I'm ready to take full credit for the effort. If not for myself, then for Rosaline. She loved the spotlight so much. I want to shine for both of us like she did for me."

"You already do," Juliet whispered.

"And you," Terdoo said, his voice dropping to a low, intimate register, "you feel like one of my dreams, Juliet. The kind I don't want to wake up from."

She is engaged to another man. The thought was a hammer in his mind, a cold reminder of the ring and the fiancé and the world that was waiting for them at the gate, but as he turned his head to face her in the darkness, the logic of the earth felt a million miles away.

He wanted her.

The realization was a visceral, violent thing that turned his blood to liquid fire. He wanted her as badly as flames needed oxygen, as badly as a drowning man needed the surface, and as Max Allais's *When the Party Ends* began to play—a stripped-back melody that signaled the approaching end of the sanctuary—Terdoo knew that he was not able to fight it now.

He was a man in love, and the war for his heart was lost but the war for hers had only just begun.

Chapter 15

Near Svalbard, Norway - Polar Night

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 12:00 PM (Sydney) / 1:00 AM (London - Day 2)

The darkness in the windowless middle suite was a thick, ink-soaked wool that pressed against the skin with a weight that felt entirely solid, and the silence between them was a heavy, textured thing that seemed to vibrate with the secrets they had yet to trade. The soft, melodic hum of Saint JHN's *The Best Part of Life* began to drift through the speakers, a looped mantra of living in the moment that seemed to coat the walls of the suite in a warm, auditory haze. They lay there in the velvet gloom of 1F, the engine's muffled roar sounding like the distant, rhythmic breathing of a sleeping giant, and Juliet felt the air in her lungs grow thin with a curiosity that had been sharpening into a needle-point since the flight began.

"How does a son of the clergy who made millions from real estate become a man who buys entire rows of a plane?" she asked, her voice a low, melodic thread in the dark, weaving through the bassline of the song. "How do you do it all without a single penny of financial support or backing from your parents?"

Terdoo shifted, the silk of the pillows rustling like dry leaves, and he felt the familiar, grounding weight of the journal on the desk nearby.

"I have to ask you a question first," he said, his voice a textured vibration that seemed to travel through the mattress and into her bones. "Have you read either of the books *An Endless Railroad?* Or *A Podium for the Soul?*"

"Nooooooo wayyyy," Juliet said, the sound a sudden, frantic burst of energy that made her sit up from her initial position, and he could feel the sudden, sharp shift in the atmosphere as her interest caught fire.

"You haven't read either?" he asked, trying to be sure, though he could not see her face in the obsidian dark.

"I mean Yes, I have. Of course I have, everyone in the world has read that book even those who cannot read," she said, her words tumbling out with a physical heat. "Those are the non-fiction books of our generation! It is what Shakespeare would write if he were in fact reincarnated in the 2020s and given a laptop. Don't tell me your company published the book?"

"What is the similarity between both books?" Terdoo asked, his tone calm and instructional.

"They were both written by the same author, Romeo Teydoux," she replied, her voice filled with a heavy, breathless reverence. "I remember the name because of how many awards he won. He never turned up on the magazines or at the award shows, but he's considered the greatest literary mind of a generation."

Terdoo took a breath, the recycled air feeling like cold silk in his throat.

"You have a stage name, Juliet, and I have a pen name," he said, and he reached out to lay his hand on the journal. "My friends and family call me Terdoo, acquaintances call me Tay, but you, Rosaline, Big Chief, very few others, and the billions who read my books around the world call me Romeo. I picked the name because I always felt a deep connection to Shakespeare."

He paused, letting the name hang in the pressurized air.

"You're only the fourth person in the world who can call me that to my face," he added, his voice dropping to a low, warning register, "so never do so in public."

Juliet moved her hands noiselessly, her fingers finding the control panel, and she adjusted the light in the suite until the room was flooded with a sudden, aggressive brightness that made Terdoo close his eyes, caught off guard by the violent intrusion of the light. When he opened them, she was just sitting there, her brown eyes wide and fixed on his face, lost in his gaze as vividly as if she were being enchanted by his very soul.

The man is a genius. The thought was a physical realization that made her heart hammer against her ribs, a beautiful, kind, deep, and nearly perfect genius.

"You wrote *A Podium for the Soul*, Terdoo?" she asked, her voice a fragile thread. "You are the author, Romeo? That would mean you won a Nobel Prize in Literature in 2019?"

"I won a lot that year, just before she died," he said, a small, somber chuckle escaping him as if winning the highest honor in the world were as normal as ordering coffee. "Yes, I have a Nobel Prize as well. I was just twenty and on top of the world."

"This is soooo overwhelming," she said, her pulse jumping in the hollow of her neck as she got to her feet and began to pace the narrow suite for some seconds before stopping to stare at him.

The music shifted then, the track changing to the ethereal, spacing-swelling intro of Zayn's *Flight of the Stars*, the sound expanding to fill the sudden brightness of the room. She picked up her phone, her fingers flying across the glass as she searched for *Romeo Teydoux*, and her breath hitched in a sudden, sharp gasp.

"That would mean you also wrote that fictional book about vampires, angels, and all those supernatural stuff. The one that got turned into a billion-dollar movie franchise just last year and got a game adaptation in January? It is considered the best fantasy book trilogy ever written. It says here you broke down the fictional creation of vampires and werewolves in the most genius and yet simplistic way."

"Yes, I actually did all that," he said, watching her, a corner of his mouth lifting in a devastating, genuine smile.

"This means you've made more than a billion just from your books alone?"

He just laughed and said nothing else, the silence between them like what you would imagine a black hole to sound like. Juliet typed his name into the phone again, her eyes scanning the screen as she found that his net worth as a business person, investor, and CEO was also over a billion. He was the heir to a real estate empire, a billion-pound conglomerate, yet he had hidden his identity with the precision of a ghost, avoiding the fame that should have swallowed him whole.

He knew she was searching him. He sat up, reaching out to take her hand and pulling her back to the bed until they were sitting face to face.

"The initial book profit was what I used to establish the conglomerate," he explained, his thumb tracing the line of her knuckles. "I wanted a hand in tech, seed funding, and crypto, but I focused mainly on publishing because that has always been my love. I needed to build my own fortress."

He took the phone from her hand and searched her name, and he saw the digits of her own success—a net worth exceeding £100 million at just twenty-four years old. He felt a sudden, warm expansion in his chest, a sensation of profound respect that made the air feel richer.

"I am proud of you," he said, his voice low and intimate. "You have overcome a lot to be great, and who we are outside this plane does not matter."

Juliet smiled, her fingers interlaced with his, and she felt a sudden, joyous laugh bubble up from her chest as she remembered the casual joke she had made when they first sat together in the dark of 1F.

"I am Juliet," she said, her gaze locking onto his, "and it seems like I actually found my Romeo."

The realization hit her like a gust of wind.

The pieces of the puzzle slammed together in her mind with a violence that left her reeling, the names, the timing, the "impossible" nature of their meeting—it wasn't just a coincidence. She stared at him, seeing the red string of fate for the first time, a script written in invisible ink that they were finally reading aloud.

Terdoo did not look surprised. He held her gaze with a steady, knowing clarity, his expression one of a man who had already stood in the middle of that storm and survived it. He had seen the script hours ago, while she was asleep in 1A, and he had already decided that he would not be a coward. He watched her process the weight of it, the way her breath caught and her eyes searched his for a sign that this was a dream.

It was no dream.

It was a collision.

It was fated.

Through the speakers, the final song began to play, the haunting, cinematic piano of Flavio Jerome's *Bring Me The Horizon* filling the space between them. They lay back together on the bed, their hands locked in the space between them, and they stared at the ceiling in a mental awe that no words could hope to capture.

Chapter 16

Suite 1F, Qantas Flight QF1

Crossing the Barents Sea

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 1:00 PM (Sydney) / 2:00 AM (London - Day 2)

The cabin was no longer bathed in the sterile white of the morning, for Terdoo had reached for the console and adjusted the circadian lighting to a specific, deep "Sunset" amber, a warm hue designed to trick the body into rest but which now served only to turn the suite into a golden sanctuary against the freezing void of the Barents Sea. Juliet sat beside him, the glow catching the copper in her hair and making the dark silk of the duvet look like liquid bronze, and the silence was no longer a wall but a bridge that they were both finally crossing with bare feet.

"You told me if the hours were fun then I have to let you read the journal," Terdoo said, his voice a low, textured vibration that seemed to harmonize with the distant thrum of the Rolls-Royce engines. "I think you've made the entire trip nice, so why not?"

He picked up the leather-bound book and handed it over, and as her fingers brushed his, the static electricity in the air spiked, a sharp needle of sensation that made her breath hitch in a sudden, jagged gasp.

The ink shimmered in the dark.

As she opened the first page, the light from the amber panels hit the black ink and it seemed to ignite, the words vibrating with a faint, iridescent glow as if they were generating their own internal heat to survive the Arctic night. It was an impossible luminescence, a fated clarity that made the letters appear to lift off the paper and hover in the air before her eyes.

On the first page, she saw a poem dated December 2019, and the weight of the words made the air in her lungs feel like cooling lead.

[

*The pain of loss, it comes in many stages,
It makes life worse, it rips out all the pages.
Without any remorse, it locks us all in cages,
We pray to the source, it frees us with progressing ages.*

*The tragedy of absence, sharp and cold,
A story whispered, never to be told.
A future vanished, brave and once so bold,
Leaving behind a spirit, worn and old.*

*Yet in the darkness, threads of strength appear,
A silent promise, to conquer every fear.
Though sorrow's shadow may forever steer,
Love's gentle spirit holds the lost one dear.*

]

Juliet felt a sudden, sharp tightening in her throat, a physical obstruction that made it hard to swallow the realization that she was reading the raw, unedited grief of a man who had been a prisoner of his own heart for seven years. She flipped past character sheets and fragmented dialogue, her fingers moving with a frantic, rhythmic energy until she found a poem dated January 2027, titled *The Magic in Redamancy*.

She had never heard the word before, but as she read the lines, the heat behind her ribs intensified until she felt as though she were standing too close to a roaring fireplace in a frozen room.

[

*It's in her eyes that I see the moon, it's with her soul that I feel the sun;
Her gentle touch, a symphony, my thumping heart begun,
Our futures a double helix, our separate journeys turn,
Into one path forever, a magical love fully done.*

*Confiscating my heart, but galvanizing my soul,
Encapsulating my thoughts, but making me whole.
Enchanting me slowly, melting me like snow,
Fleeting feelings now staying, they continue to grow.*

*My world was shadowed, gray before your light,
But now like starshine, both radiant and bright.
Your presence near, dispels all former fright,
Transforming darkness into endless day and night.*

*In every glance, a promise I discern,
A shared devotion, a sweet lesson to learn.
With every breath, my body for you will burn,
A love reciprocated, a volcano? A heartburn.*

]

Redamancy. The act of loving in return. The thought was a physical weight, a sudden liquefaction of her resolve that made her limbs feel heavy and warm. She skipped a poem about the ancient, rugged beauty of Australia, her eyes searching only for the mirror of her own soul,

and she found the page dated the 13th—yesterday, after the bar, after John, after the walls had first begun to crack.

[
*My brown eyed girl in a black cut dress,
She brings me comfort,
She leaves me blessed.*

*My brown eyed girl with the pink-inked lips,
She keeps me mellow,
She gives me bliss.*

*My brown eyed girl with those bright brown eyes,
She sees my spirit,
She feels the highs.*

*My brown eyed girl with her graceful walk,
She moves with purpose,
She makes me talk.*

*My brown eyed girl with the wildest laugh,
A perfect memory,
My better half.*

*My brown eyed girl with her secrets untold,
A timeless story,
More precious than gold.*

*My brown eyed girl with her quiet grace,
A light that follows,
In every space.*

]

The corners of her mouth tugged upward by an invisible string, and she felt a sudden, buoyant lightness in her chest that made the pressurized cabin feel like a vast, open field. She looked at him, her heart taking a dive off a cliff without a parachute, and she saw the way he was watching her, his expression a carefully guarded fortress that was currently being besieged by the truth of his own ink.

"Ben and Bea were the muses," Terdoo joked, his voice rough and lighter than usual, though the sudden, sharp raise of his brows betrayed the lie. "Their love made it very easy to write about the concept of it. It's just random imagery, Juliet. Fiction."

"Fiction doesn't describe pink-inked lips with that kind of precision," she countered, her gaze locking onto his, and for a heartbeat, the amber light of the suite seemed to vibrate with the frequency of their shared pulse. *He sees me. He has seen me since the very first hour.*

The music suddenly cut out.

The ethereal, synth-pop rhythm of Bazzi's *Somewhere in Between* had been pulsing through the suite, its lyrics about being caught in a dream mirroring the suspended reality of the last hour, but the audio suddenly fractured into a violent, static hiss that seemed to bypass the general cabin speakers and feed directly into the suite's system. The entertainment screen flickered into a jagged fracture of black-and-white static, and the "Sunset" amber light pulsed once, twice, before settling into a cold, clinical dimness that made the room feel suddenly, terrifyingly small.

Then came the voice of the Captain.

It was stripped of all professional veneer, breathless, and edged with the terrifying clarity of a man who knows the odds are no longer in his favor, and the words fell into the suite like cold iron.

"This is the flight deck; we have suffered a catastrophic dual-engine failure and are losing altitude rapidly, so please return to your seats immediately and brace for impact."

They were falling.

Chapter 17

Coast of Norway / Entering the North Sea

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 2:00 PM (Sydney) / 3:00 AM (London - Day 2)

The upbeat pulse of the music vanished in a violent, jagged burst of static that seemed to bypass the suite's physical speakers and vibrate directly into the marrow of their bones, and the "Sunset" amber light flickered once before settling into a bruised, flickering purple that made the room feel suddenly, terrifyingly small. Terdoo did not scream, and he did not scramble for the oxygen masks that had yet to fall, but the heat left his skin in a sudden, cooling wave that made his breath hitch in a jagged, uneven rhythm.

The wine in the glass remained perfectly level.

Despite the audio roaring through the suite, the liquid in the crystal glass did not spill or even ripple. It sat like a solid, unmoving ruby, a geometric impossibility that suggested the laws of physics had been suspended for the duration of their final act.

Then came the voice of Captain Adam Duncan Kent, stripped of all professional veneer and edged with the terrifying clarity of a man who knows the odds.

"Ladies and gentlemen... this is the Captain speaking. Listen to me. We have suffered a catastrophic fuel starvation error. We have lost thrust in all four engines. We are currently at thirty thousand feet and falling rapidly. We do not have the altitude to reach land."

Terdoo's blood ran cold, and he looked at Juliet, seeing his own end reflected in the wide, dark terror of her eyes.

"To avoid a high-speed impact, I am initiating an emergency descent," the voice continued, cracking with a strain that sounded like tearing metal. "We are going to attempt a water landing in the freezing ocean. It is going to be violent. Assume the brace position immediately. Head down, hands over your head. Do not look up until we have come to a complete stop. God help us all."

The audio cut with a sharp, final snap.

Terdoo moved with a sudden, predatory grace, not to save himself, but to ensure that the woman beside him was the only thing the world couldn't touch. He reached for Juliet, his fingers crushing hers with a desperate strength, and he pulled her forward until she was folded over in the seat, her red hair a frantic spill across his knees. He threw his own frame over hers, a human

shield of corded muscle, offering his back to the impact so that she might have one extra second of breath.

This is the tax. The thought was a javelin in his mind, a cold realization that the names they carried were finally demanding their price. *It is the expected thing for Romeo and Juliet to die.* He closed his eyes, his forehead pressed against the back of her neck, and he accepted the darkness with a paralyzed clarity that made the approaching water feel like a homecoming.

Juliet was a riot of noise in her own mind, but as Terdoo's weight settled over her, she thought only of the man shielding her from the sky. *Walking away from him on the ground would have been the real death.*

One. Two. Ten. Twenty.

Instead of the shattering of the fuselage, Terdoo felt a soft, gentle tap on his shoulder.

He flinched, a violent, full-body shudder, and his head snapped up as he prepared to face the chaos. Instead, he saw Catherine, the Customer Service Manager, standing calmly in the aisle with a professional, knowing smile. The aircraft was level. The engines were clearly audible, humming their steady, powerful rhythm through the floorboards.

She offered a silver tray with a heavy bottle of vintage Penfolds Grange and a folded piece of cream cardstock. "Mr. Terdoo? Ms. Juliet?" she whispered. "Captain Kent asked me to bring this to you. He said you might need a stiff drink about now."

Terdoo reached out with a trembling hand and took the note. It was handwritten in Adam's distinctive, messy scrawl.

Terdoo,

Gotcha.

That little "engine failure" audio track was played exclusively to Suite 1F. The perks of having access to the IFE override system. We have plenty of fuel, the engines are purring, and we are cruising perfectly toward the UK. The "emergency descent" was just a little turbulence I timed with the audio.

Welcome to the final leg, mate. Drinks are on me tonight. (But drink this bottle first, you both look like you've seen a ghost).

— *The First Man*

Terdoos stared at the note, the adrenaline slowly draining away, replaced by a mix of disbelief and overwhelming relief. He looked up at Catherine, who was struggling to suppress a giggle, and then at Juliet, who was staring at the bottle of wine as if it were a holy relic.

"He said to tell you that's for the time you put glad wrap on his toilet seat in college," Catherine added.

Terdoos exhaled a long, shaky breath, fell back into the sheepskin chair, and finally, he started to laugh. He reached for the console and tapped the screen, and the melancholic, mid-tempo beat of Bex's *Holiday Heartbreaks* began to drift from the speakers, the lyrics serving as a shield against the raw intimacy of the last two minutes. They both focused on the silver foil of the wine bottle, their hands moving with a synchronized energy to avoid having to talk about the fact that they had just prepared to die in each other's arms.

"Open it," she whispered.

"We need the whole bottle," he agreed.

Chapter 18

Crossing the North Sea toward the UK Coast

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 3:00 PM (Sydney) / 4:00 AM (London - Day 2)

The melancholic, acoustic swell of Seafret's *Most of Us are Strangers* drifted through the suite, the lyrics of distance and hidden depths mirroring the heavy, textured silence that had settled between them, and they sat in the dim amber light, staring at the deep ruby of the Penfolds Grange in their glasses before Terdoo finally extended his hand to pass her the note. Juliet took the cream cardstock, her fingers brushing his with a lingering, electric heat, and she read the messy scrawl of the Captain's message while the liquid in her glass remained perfectly still despite the faint shudder of the aircraft's wings.

The note remained at exactly ninety-eight degrees.

As she held the card, she realized the paper did not lose its warmth to the pressurized air of the cabin, but instead stayed at the precise temperature of a human palm, as if the "First Man" were still holding the other side of it. It was a fated, impossible heat that ignored the laws of thermodynamics.

"Why does he call himself the First Man?" she asked, her voice a low vibration that barely rose above the piano melody.

Terdoo took a slow sip of the wine, the weight of the last seven years shifting behind his ribs, and he explained that back in university, he had developed a strange, writerly aversion to the name Adam. To a younger Terdoo, the name was a symbol of the man who had doomed humanity to an existence of labor and stress, a literary catalyst for the fall of grace, and he had made his opinions known with the arrogant, intellectual fire of a twenty-year-old. Adam Kent had simply laughed, reminding Terdoo daily that regardless of his philosophical theories, Adam would always be "The First Man," and the moniker had stayed long after the classrooms had faded.

Juliet laughed softly, a sound of genuine wonder as she imagined a younger, more arrogant version of the man sitting across from her. *He was a genius even then, a deep thinker who saw the world as a library of tragedies.*

"I didn't need to ask how you knew him," she said, her expression shifting into a smug, knowing look as she sipped her wine.

"Oh, you didn't?" Terdoo asked, a faint smirk touching his lips.

"Yes, of course," she replied, her brown eyes dancing with a playful mischief. "Miss Catherine clearly said you pranked him back in college. It's obvious."

Terdoo moved closer, his presence invading her space until the scent of vanilla and expensive wine was the only thing she could perceive, and he whispered a single word into the quiet between them.

"Wrong."

"That's not how you met?" she asked, her confusion a physical tension in her brow.

"We met in school, yes, and I played pranks on everyone—on him, on Rose, on anyone I could find a fracture point in," he admitted, his voice dropping to a gravelly register. "We were friends then, but we weren't close. He was three years ahead of my class, a man already looking at the sky while I was still looking at the page."

"So what happened to make you two this close?" she asked, gesturing toward the note and the sheer, calculated madness of the prank he had just executed.

Terdoo gave a soft, hollow laugh that didn't reach his eyes, and the air in the suite grew suddenly, sharply cold. He looked down at his glass, and the memory of 2019 rose up to meet him like a physical blow. He narrated the story to her, telling her how he, Adam, and Rosaline had all attended the same university, but their bond hadn't been forged in the classrooms or the bars. It had been forged in the cabin of a G650 private charter, high above the Atlantic, in a silence that was heavier than the sea.

He didn't treat her like cargo. The thought was a raw, visceral thing in his mind. He treated her like a queen.

He told Juliet about sitting alone in that cabin, staring at a polished mahogany box that was strapped down across the aisle, drinking whiskey to numb a pain that had no bottom. Adam Kent, who was then a private charter pilot before moving to commercial, hadn't stayed in the cockpit to maintain a professional distance. When the turbulence had hit, he had come back to the cabin, not to serve a drink or offer a hollow platitude, but just to sit with Terdoo in the dark. They had sat in a shared, unbreakable silence for what to him felt like an eternity, a nod of solidarity between the man who had lost his world and the man who was flying it home.

When they had finally landed, it was Adam who had stayed with him in the penthouse hotel, making sure that the loneliest version of Terdoo wasn't left to face the quiet alone.

"That trip changed everything," Terdoo whispered, his knuckles white as he gripped his glass. "That is why I trust him with my life today."

Juliet felt a sudden, sharp tightening in her throat, a physical reaction to the poetic, heartbreaking weight of the story. She looked at him, and the "Noir" reality of his life felt more textured, more real, than anything she had ever experienced on the ground.

The same man had flown the only woman I ever loved away from me and our dreams together and now he was flying me to someone who was a complete stranger that now had all of my heart.

Terdoos stared at Juliet, and for the first time in the flight, the "First Man" didn't feel like a figure from a story or a pilot in a cockpit. He felt like a guardian of the red string that was currently pulling them toward a London dawn.

Chapter 19

Crossing the North Sea

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 4:00 PM (Sydney) / 5:00 AM (London - Day 2)

The low, melodic yearning of The Script's *The Man Who Can't Be Moved* pulsed through the windowless suite, a rhythmic heartbeat of acoustic guitar and soft percussion that seemed to anchor them to the dark sky, and they sat together in the intimate, pressurized silence of Suite 1F as the "Ground" began its slow, inevitable pull toward their lives. They were still dressed in the powerful, tailored boarding clothes they had worn nearly twenty hours ago, and the fabric felt like a heavy armor that had been dented by the gravity of the last day, but their hands were locked together in the space between them with a strength that ignored the altitude.

The steam from the botanical tea rose in a single, vertical thread.

As they sat before the remnants of the Neil Perry "Wellbeing" menu, the vapor from the herbal infusion did not dissipate or swirl with the air conditioning, but instead stood like a solid silver needle that connected the table to the ceiling. It remained perfectly still, a fated defiance of the aircraft's forward motion that suggested the air itself was holding its breath.

"I feel surprisingly sharp for hour twenty," Terdoo noted, his voice a low, grounded vibration that showed no signs of the marathon flight's fatigue.

"I was just thinking the same thing," Juliet agreed, her gaze dropping to the empty wellness shot glass on the tray. "There is no brain fog at all, and usually, by this point in a long-haul, I feel like I'm moving through wet concrete, but right now I feel like I could walk straight onto a stage and perform for three hours." She looked at him, and the way the dim cabin lighting caught the sharpness of his features made her chest feel suddenly, sharply tight. *He looks like a king who has forgotten he has a kingdom.*

"I have a stressful family event later today," Terdoo admitted, the thought of his sister's wedding casting a brief, cooling shadow over his expression, but he did not mention the ceremony or the bride. "It is the kind of day that requires a version of me I haven't been in a very long time, and I find myself wondering if the London air will let me keep the clarity I found up here."

"I have a high-paying emergency gig for an important client on the same day," Juliet whispered, her fingers tightening around his. "It was a last-minute request through my manager, and the money was too significant to ignore, but the thought of the crowd feels like a weight I'm not ready to carry back yet."

A soft, melodic laugh bubbled up from her chest as the irony of the date settled between them.

**Her laughter was a sudden, sharp clarity.
It rippled through the pressurized air like a stone thrown into a still pond.
The sound was a warm expansion in the center of his chest.**

"We both have to work on the most romantic day of the year," she mused, shaking her head at the absurdity of it. "Valentine's Day in London, and the two of us are heading straight into the teeth of the world instead of hiding from it."

"Perhaps the world is just impatient for our return," Terdoo replied, though the "Cold Void" behind his ribs felt as though it had been permanently replaced by the heat of her hand in his. *She is going to a stage, and I am going to a fortress, and the miles between us are already beginning to hurt.*

He looked at his phone, the screen glowing with the relentless approach of the London dawn, and he stood up with a fluid, decisive grace. He stretched out his hand for her to take, his eyes locking onto hers with a devastating intensity that made her knees feel like water.

"We have another sunrise to catch in Suite 1K," he said, the single sentence carrying the weight of a promise that the night was finally over.

Chapter 20

Banking over the Dutch Coast

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 5:00 PM (Sydney) / 6:00 AM (London - Day 2)

They entered Suite 1K, and the space felt like a chapel carved from walnut and glass that had been scrubbed clean of the night, and the smooth, Afro-fusion pulse of Magixx's *Bad Decisions and foreplay* began to drift through the cabin, the lyrics of desire and consequence weaving through the rhythmic thrum of the air conditioning. There were no remnants of breakfast on the table, no scattered menus or empty glasses, and the 32-inch 4K monitor was the only light in the room until the horizon began to bleed.

The sun on the screen was exactly the same size as the sun in the window.

Despite the wide-angle distortion of the external tail camera and the natural optics of the panoramic glass, the two glowing orbs were identical in scale, a fated synchronization of technology and nature that suggested the world was perfectly aligned for their arrival. It was an impossible visual harmony, a shared reality where the silver bird and the celestial body were moving in a choreographed dance that only they were invited to watch.

Outside, the Dutch coast was a bruised purple line that began to crack open, and a thin thread of molten platinum spilled across the cloud tops, illuminating the dark expanse of the North Sea in a way that made the heart stutter. Terdoo looked from the window to the monitor, watching the aircraft bank in a majestic sweep that felt like a slow-motion reset of his entire existence, and the "Cold Void" that had defined his silhouette for seven years was finally, violently erased by the light.

The light was a physical hand on his throat.

It forced the last of the winter from his marrow.

The warmth turned the blood in his veins to flowing lava.

It is no longer a want. The realization hit him with the force of a physical blow, a sudden, sharp clarity that made the pressurized air feel like pure oxygen in a vacuum. *I need her.* He looked at Juliet, her face bathed in the ethereal, shifting colors of the rebirth, and he saw the way the sunlight turned every strand of her hair to the same brilliance of the red leaves on a maple tree in autumn.

"Who is this?" she asked, her voice a fragile melody that seemed to rise and fall with the transition into Magixx's *Bad decisions and Foreplay*.

"He's a really good Nigerian artiste," Terdoo replied, his voice a low, grounded vibration that anchored the magical moment to the floorboards.

They sat together in a silence that was no longer heavy or textured, but light and airy, as if the gravity of the Earth had lost its hold on them 40,000 feet above the coast. There were no words left to trade, and there was no need for the distractions of the ground, for the second sunrise was a physical healing that was stitching their wounds together with threads of gold.

Juliet watched the world wake up through the panoramic window, and she felt the static electricity in the air shift into a steady, radiant heat that made the center of her chest feel as though it were expanding beyond the limits of her dress. *I am forty thousand feet in the sky, and for the first time in twenty-four years, I am no longer a runaway.*

They remained locked in the moment, two figures in a silver tube conquering the world, and as the light flooded the suite until the shadows were completely gone, they understood that the "expected" ending was no longer the only one written in the stars.

Chapter 21

Suite 1F & Suite 1K, *Crossing the English Channel*

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 6:00 PM (Sydney) / 7:00 AM (London - Day 2)

The morning light over the English Channel was a sharp, crystalline silver that seemed to vibrate against the panoramic windows of the aircraft, and they sat together in the pressurized stillness of Suite 1K as the final hour began to settle over them like a heavy, unseen weight. Juliet was hunched over her phone, her thumb moving in a restless, rhythmic scroll that didn't seem to register the data on the screen, and across from her, Terdoo held his leather-bound journal with a grip that turned his knuckles into white stones, but neither of them reached for the air that sat between them.

The shadow of the wing stayed perfectly still.

Despite the slight banking of the aircraft as it followed the descent path toward Heathrow, the shadow cast by the massive wing onto the cloud deck below remained frozen in place, a fated defiance of the plane's movement that suggested they were caught in a pocket of time that refused to surrender to the ground.

The door to the suite slid open with a soft, clinical hiss, and Diana, the air hostess, stood there with a calm, professional mask that signaled the end of their sanctuary. "Mr. Terdoo, Ms. Juliet," she said, her voice a polite intrusion into the quiet. "We are beginning our final descent into London, so I must ask you to return to your designated suites and ensure you are seated and strapped in for landing protocol."

She extended a small silver tray with two steaming, lemon-scented towels, offering them the final hot towel service to wake their senses—a gentle 'Arrival Revival' ritual to bridge the gap between the dreamscape of the flight and the reality of the ground.

Terdoo stood up, the movement fluid and predatory, and he offered her a smile that didn't quite reach the heavy tightness behind his eyes. He gathered his things, but as he stepped toward the door, the sound of a phone hitting the carpeted floor echoed through the suite like a gunshot.

Juliet had dropped her device, her breath coming in a sudden, jagged gasp, and she walked toward the threshold where he stood. "Hey," she said, her voice a fragile thread that barely rose above the cabin's hum.

Terdoo stopped at the door of his own suite, 1F, and turned back to face her. "Hey you," he replied, his voice a low, grounded vibration.

She paused, the outgoing version of herself having vanished to reveal a raw, textured silence that left her short of words for the first time in her life. She looked at him, and the distance between their suites felt like a vast, uncrossable canyon. "I'll see you when we land," she finally managed, the sentence carrying the weight of a prayer.

Terdoo simply smiled and nodded, and then the doors slid shut, sealing them into their separate worlds.

In Suite 1K, the silence rushed in to fill the space where his voice had been, and Juliet sat on the edge of the bed, her fingers tracing the seam of her dress. The suite was too quiet, a sterile vacuum without the low hum of his playlist or the rhythmic scratching of his pen. *I really hate how quiet it is without him.*

She leaned her head back, and her mind drifted back to the amber glow of the 1F suite, and she remembered the way the ink in his journal had seemed to breathe under her touch. She saw the words *The Magic in Redamancy* burned into her retinas, a promise of a love reciprocated that she hadn't dared to believe in until the sky had forced her to see it. She remembered the way he had spoken of the hot air balloons in Switzerland, the multicolored lanterns drifting over the white silence of the Alps, and how the world had felt small and manageable when he was the one holding the map. Most of all, she remembered John, the way his silver hair had caught the dim light of the bar and how his voice had been a calm anchor in the storm of their debate. *He told me to go where it is supposed to find me, and I think I'm already there.*

In Suite 1F, Terdoo adjusted the lighting to a dim, bruised purple that matched the shadow behind his ribs, and the speakers began to pulse with the melancholic, soaring piano of James Bay's *Goodbye Never Felt So Bad*. The shuffle of the playlist had delivered the coincidence with a surgical precision that made him let out a soft, hallowed laugh. "I really loved that song before now," he murmured to the empty room, but the lyrics now felt like a jagged piece of glass shifting in his heart.

He closed his eyes, and he saw Juliet at the lounge bar, her black dress slipping off her shoulder as she laughed at something Ben had said. He remembered the uninhibited, playful way she had tossed olives into the air, her eyes bright with a childish joy as she caught them in her mouth with a perfect, rhythmic precision. He saw the way she attacked her Shakshuka with a hunger for life that he had forgotten was possible, and he remembered the physical heat of her body sitting on his lap in the golden glow of the sunrise. *She is the radiant chaos I've been trying to keep out, and now I can't breathe without the smoke.*

He thought of John too, the way the man had polished the glasses in slow, meditative circles, offering a middle path that Terdoo had spent seven years trying to find. The mystery of

the man's existence—the dry counter, the empty manifest—no longer felt like a riddle to be solved, but a gift to be cherished.

The descent continued, the pressure in the cabin shifting as they dropped through the clouds over England, yet Terdoo noticed the absence of the usual pressure headache or the sharp popping in his ears. The A350's lower cabin altitude had done its work; instead of the exhaustion that usually accompanied twenty-three hours in the sky, he felt a surge of vitality. He felt physically ready to fight for her because the plane hadn't drained him; it had recharged him.

The recap of the journey spun through their individual minds like a reel of fated film.

"I need to tell her," Terdoo said audibly, his voice a gravelly register of resolve that cut through the James Bay track.

At the exact same moment, in the quiet of 1K, Juliet spoke to the empty air. "I need to tell him."

Terdoo sat forward, staring at the entertainment screen as the PA announcement for the final landing approach began to drone through the cabin. He was away from her for the first time in a while, and the realization hit him with the force of a physical blow.

He did not like it.

Chapter 22

Suite 1K & The First Class Aisle, *Landing at London Heathrow*

Date: 14th February, 2027

Time: 7:00 PM (Sydney) / 8:00 AM (London - Day 2)

The tires screamed as they bit into the rain-slicked tarmac of Heathrow, a violent, jarring reminder that the laws of the earth had finally reclaimed them, and the roar of the thrust reversers was a deafening, industrial howl that seemed to tear the very air from the cabin, but Terdoo did not wait for the deceleration to finish. The "Fasten Seatbelt" sign was still a glowing red command against the walnut trim, but his fingers were already moving with a frantic, rhythmic precision to release the latch, and the click of the metal was a sharp, final punctuation to the last twenty-three hours. He stood up, his limbs feeling heavy with the sudden return of gravity, and he stepped out of Suite 1F with the focused, predatory grace of a man who was no longer running from his ghosts.

The rain on the window moved upward.

Despite the forward momentum of the taxiing aircraft and the heavy pull of the London wind, the droplets on the panoramic glass of the corridor did not streak backward, but instead began to crawl vertically toward the sky in perfect, parallel lines. It was a fated, impossible rebellion against physics, a sign that the ground they had just touched was not yet ready to impose its logic on the story they had written in the clouds.

Terdoo stopped at the door of Suite 1K, his breath coming in short, shallow bursts that made his chest feel as though it were being crushed by a phantom weight. He did not knock, and he did not wait for the electronic latch to hiss open, but he leaned his forehead against the cool wood of the door and began to speak into the stillness.

"I have only known you for the duration of one Qantas flight and two sunrises," he started, his voice a raw, gravelly register that vibrated through the partition and into the quiet of her suite. "I know that what I am about to say makes absolutely no sense from a logical point of view, and I know that the world outside this door is waiting to turn us back into the strangers we were in Sydney, but I cannot let the air between us grow cold without telling you the truth. I have spent seven years building a fortress of silence to keep the world out, and I have used my wealth to buy a solitude that I thought was my only salvation, but then you walked into that lounge and the second hand on my watch stopped moving for three beats."

He paused, his hand gripping the frame of the door until the wood groaned.

"I saw the sun in your hair before it even rose, and I felt the heat of your soul in the middle of a polar night, and I realized that the poems I've been writing my entire life were just a

long, rhythmic rehearsal for the moment I met you. I am a man of honor, Juliet, but I am a man in love even more, and I will not let you walk out of this plane and into the arms of some other man named Ferdinand. I won't let you go back to a life that is expected when we have found something that is impossible."

The door slid open.

Juliet stood there, her red hair a riot of chaotic light against the dim cabin glow, and her brown eyes were wide and wet with a sudden, shimmering heat that made the center of his chest feel as though it were expanding beyond the limits of his ribs. She didn't look like a star or a performer; she looked like a woman who had finally found the surface after a lifetime of treading water.

"I called off the engagement," she whispered, her voice a fragile, beautiful melody that stripped the last of the "Noir" shadow from the corridor. "The night we spoke at the bar, Terdoo. The night we had our mini first date and you left your suite to go to economy class—do you remember? I got into this suite and I sat on the floor and I realized that I couldn't breathe the same air as him ever again. I got my phone out before I even got into bed and I called him and I told him it was over. There is no one waiting at the gate, Romeo. There is no one waiting for me but you."

Terdoo felt the blood drain from his face, replaced by a sudden, violent warmth that turned his marrow to liquid gold.

"I fell for you the moment I saw you slamming that boarding pass down like a weapon," she confessed, stepping into his space until the scent of vanilla was a physical weight on his senses. "I saw the mystery in your eyes and I wanted to spend the rest of my life mapping the depths behind it. I didn't find a stranger in Suite 1A; I found the other half of my own helix, and the connection I feel right now is infinite. It has no fracture points."

He reached out.

His hands found her waist.

She threw her arms around his neck.

The impact of their bodies was a sudden, sharp clarity that made the pressurized air of the cabin feel like pure oxygen, and they kissed with a desperate, uninhibited passion that ignored the fact that they were still on a plane at 8:00 AM on a Sunday morning. It was a kiss of absolute surrender, a physical sealing of the treaty they had negotiated over thirty thousand miles and seven pillars of conversation, and the black hole that he had been was finally, permanently extinguished by the radiant fire of their shared breath.

The war was over.

A sudden, thunderous burst of applause and cheers erupted from the aisle behind them, and they broke apart, breathless and flushed, to see Ben and Bea standing by their own suite, their faces alight with a joyous, uninhibited triumph. Beside them stood Diane and Catherine, the air hostesses' professional masks having finally slipped to reveal the genuine warmth of people who had spent twenty-three hours watching a miracle unfold.

"About bloody time, mate!" Ben shouted, his voice echoing through the first-class cabin with a booming, celebratory energy. "I thought I'd have to push you together myself! I've been holding my breath since the Arabian Sea!"

Bea laughed, wiping a tear from her cheek as she leaned into Ben's side. "You look good together," she repeated, her voice a soft, final validation that reached their hearts.

Terdoo looked at Juliet, his hand still locked in hers, and the sound of the clapping was a rhythmic heartbeat that matched the sudden, steady thudding of his own. The London rain was still streaking on the glass, and the ground was waiting for them with its schedules and its crowds, but as he pulled her closer for one final, lingering touch, he knew that they were exactly where they were supposed to be.

14th February, 2027

Time: 8:15 AM (London Time)

The heavy, pressurized seal of the aircraft was finally broken as the door swung open to reveal the jet bridge, and the air that rushed in was no longer the recycled, sterile oxygen of the clouds, but a cool, damp draft that smelled of London rain and jet fuel, but the "Qantas Bubble" did not burst as they stepped out. They walked hand in hand, their fingers interlaced with a strength that made the physical world feel like a secondary concern, and Ben and Bea followed close behind them, their laughter a bright, uninhibited symphony that echoed against the corrugated walls of the tunnel.

The phone signal hit the bars with a crystalline chime.

Despite the shielded thickness of the airport's infrastructure and the usual interference of the terminal, Terdoo's phone erupted into life with a signal so strong and a sound so clear it felt as though the tower were standing inside his own mind. It was a fated, impossible connection, a final umbilical cord of the sky that refused to let them go until the last truth was spoken.

They were met at the end of the bridge by James and Sarah, the London First Lounge hosts, who waited with silver tablets and professional smiles to whisk them through the private channel, bypassing the Sunday morning chaos of Heathrow with the effortless grace that wealth and fate had commanded.

"You two are coming with us," Terdoo said, turning back to Ben and Bea, his voice a low, grounded vibration that brooked no argument. "I have a family function today—a gathering that requires the presence of people who have seen the sun rise from the right side of the world—and I want you there to witness the rest of the story."

"Where is it?" Ben asked, grinning as he adjusted the strap of his bag. "Give us a location so we can tell our parents we aren't just disappearing into the London fog."

Terdoo began to give the address of the sprawling estate in Kent, but he only got through the first three words before Juliet stopped in her tracks, her hand tightening around his with a force that made him turn to face her.

"His younger sister, Queen, is getting married," she said, her voice a fragile melody that seemed to resonate with the very air of the terminal.

Terdoo looked at her, his expression a map of sudden, sharp surprise that made his eyes widen into dark pools of wonder. "I know I told you her name was Queen," he said, his voice dropping to a gravelly register of disbelief, "but I never told you the location, or that the 'family function' I was so worried about was actually her wedding."

Juliet began to laugh, a wild, joyous sound that rippled through the quiet corridor like a stone thrown into a still pond, and she pulled her own phone from her pocket to show him the location for her "emergency gig." It was the exact same coordinate, the same estate, the same hour. She looked at the booking details, at the name of the primary contact, and she felt the static electricity in the air turn into a radiant, blinding heat.

**The world tilted on its axis.
The red string finally tightened.
The silence was a warm expansion.**

Just then, his phone vibrated against his palm, and he saw the name of his secretary flashing on the screen. He picked it up, knowing with a terrifying clarity that this call had nothing to do with business and everything to do with the universe. He spoke for a few seconds, his gaze locked onto Juliet's, and then he ended the call and let out a laugh that was louder and more uninhibited than any sound he had made in seven years.

He pulled her into a hug, his arms a solid, protective barrier against the reality of the ground, and they stood there in the middle of the private channel, laughing together as the realization settled into their marrow.

"I am the emergency client," he whispered into her hair, the irony a physical heat in his chest. "I told my secretary to find the best, to pay whatever it took to make Queen's day perfect because she has been obsessed with your music since her first year of university, but I never looked at the manifest. I let the details fade into the background while I was busy looking for a way to survive the quiet."

"I was coming to find you anyway," she laughed, her eyes wet with a sudden, radiant heat. "I was coming to sing for your sister, and I didn't even know it was your family."

They were fated to meet.

It didn't matter if they had taken different flights, or if Terdoo hadn't bought the entire row, or if John hadn't offered his "middle path" at the bar; the universe had been moving the pieces on the board since the day they were born. They were a double helix of separate journeys that had always been intended to collide at a Sunday wedding in Kent.

They walked out of Heathrow together, their shoulders brushing as they moved through the lounge toward the waiting cars, and as they entered the terminal, the speakers in the ceiling began to pulse with a familiar rhythm. It was Terdoo's favorite song of all time—a track he had listened to in the dark of a thousand hotel rooms—but as the melody filled the London morning, it became the soundtrack of their beginning.

The air outside was cold and smelled of winter, but as they stepped into the light of Valentine's Day, they were no longer looking for what they didn't have.

They were home.

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The Author's Note: A Study in Redamancy

Writing in the "Introspective Noir" style is an exercise in restraint. In these pages, you did not find the words *love*, *grief*, or *joy* used as labels. Instead, I invited you to feel the static electricity in the air, the cold stone in the throat, and the sudden warmth of a radiator in a long-vacant room.

The human experience is not a list of definitions; it is a series of physical reactions to a world that is often too loud to process. By removing the labels, I hoped to bring you closer to the "double helix" of Romeo and Juliet—not as archetypes, but as two souls vibrating at the same frequency thirty thousand feet above the Earth.

Redamancy is the act of loving in return. It is the realization that the universe is not a vacuum, but a conversation. I hope this flight has allowed you to find your own middle path.

About the Author

David "The k!nG" Orkwar is a 25-year-old aspiring multihyphenate based in Abuja, Nigeria, with ambitions to define his future in New York City. A profound lover of books from a young age, he has spent years honing his craft in the dark, building on over **1,000,000 words of fiction** written anonymously.

David's intellectual depth is anchored by a **Degree in Computer Science** and a **Diploma in Theology**, complemented by academic honors including a gold medal from the **Mathematical Association of Nigeria**. A self-proclaimed lover of the classics, David had completed five Shakespeare plays and numerous literary masterpieces by age twelve, finding beauty in the precision of authors from Judith McNaught to Dan Brown.

His insightful, confident approach and sharp wit allow him to navigate the "Noir" complexities of the human condition with passion and a distinct penchant for humor. When he isn't exploring the depths of **Fantasy**, **Supernatural**, and **Sci-Fi**.

